1 Conserving *Limitless Life*

> "All the more I felt the misgivings which the very hugeness of the deposit was bound to inspire as to the possibility of a thorough methodical search."
> – Stein, *Serindia,* vol. 2, 809

Documenting 1,492 copies of the *Sutra of Limitless Life* (henceforth *Ap,* for *Aparimitāyurnāma sūtra*), we found ourselves wrestling with the history of their conservation and cataloguing. The sutra copies kept in London are unique in that curators transformed them from roll format into booklet format for ease of storage, something that was not done in the case of the sutra copies kept elsewhere. The methods for documenting and conserving these manuscripts were not well described in the accounts of Stein, nor in the catalogues and works of Louis de La Vallée Poussin (1869–1938), F.W. Thomas (1867–1956), Zuihō Yamaguchi, and Sam van Schaik. The most important evidence for piecing together these manuscripts' conservation history, therefore, apart from the published catalogues, are the notes that curators and cataloguers wrote on the manuscripts or onto slips of paper that are kept alongside them.

Following these clues has enabled us to more clearly understand the process of documentation and conservation of these manuscripts to a degree that illuminates the history of these sutra copies' storage and use. Since these manuscripts represent a significant cross section of the Stein Collection, our insights into the processes and methods by which Stein and, assistants, and later curators assigned site numbers are also relevant to the collection and its history more generally.

Our investigation has also shown how Louis de La Vallée Poussin, during his cataloguing work in Cambridge from 1914 to 1918, marked and numbered the individual 31.5 × 45 cm panels of paper of each roll of Tibetan *Ap* copies in order to prepare them for binding. The 1,055 rolls of Tibetan *Ap* in the Stein Collection were not among the many Dunhuang manuscripts that were bound into seventy-three large leather-bound books known as "volumes" during the 1910s and 1920s. They were, however, eventually bound into short paper booklets, presumably for ease of storing and conservation. As a result, each of the 31.5 × 45 cm panels of paper that made up the rolls was separated, folded in half, stacked with two to five of its neighboring panels, and bound at the spine with Kraft paper to create a thin booklet. This type of booklet mimicked the style of Chinese "butterfly binding," albeit with the addition of a Kraft paper spine. Whereas a roll containing one sutra might be transformed into a single such booklet, longer rolls with multiple *Ap* copies were transformed into between two and fifteen booklets. Each of these newly created

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booklets was assigned a pressmark, or a sub-pressmark within one pressmark, ITJ 310, which was meant to include all of the Tibetan Dunhuang *Ap* copies in roll format. In this way, 1,055 rolls containing 1,492 sutra copies became 1,339 pressmarks, the vast majority of which are found in the sequence of sub-pressmarks that run from ITJ 310.1 to ITJ 310.1210. Documenting this process of conservation and cataloguing helps us to better understand the objects that we are working with, and the meanings of the various marks and numbers that different hands have left upon them.

Most importantly, Stein and his assistants assigned site numbers to these sutra copies, which allow us to see which copies belong together. It also reveals some meaningful distributions of the different types of *Ap* sutra copies in this collection, permitting us to propose a plausible reconstruction of the processes that produced them in ninth-century Dunhuang.

1.1 Bundles of manuscripts in Dunhuang

The story of the discovery of Dunhuang's Cave Seventeen – often called the "library cave" – and the tale of Sir Marc Aurel Stein's negotiating the removal to India and England of many of its treasures, has been told many times. Stein himself gives an initial version in his 1912 two-volume work, *Ruins of Desert Cathay*, and an expanded version in his 1921 five-volume work, *Serindia*. There is no need to recount the narrative in detail here, but there are a few points within the story that are relevant to the site numbers written on the Chinese and Tibetan Dunhuang *Ap* copies now kept at the British Library, and to the different bundles of manuscripts and objects in which they were initially found.

Stein and his "secretary" Jiang Xiaowan (see Fig. 6) had access to Cave Seventeen for only a short period of time, from May 23 to May 29, 1907. They had already consulted a few manuscripts shared with them by the Daoist monk, Wang Yuanlu, who was looking after the Mogao caves. Among these few initial manuscripts was one whose colophon mentioned the famous Tang-dynasty monk and traveler Xuanzang, and this aided Stein and Jiang in their attempts to persuade Wang that Stein was a sort of latter-day Xuanzang, come as a pilgrim from India to bring sacred texts back to India and to England.[1] Jiang's role in supporting and positioning Stein

1 Stein 1921, vol. 2, 805–807, 812–813. The first manuscript that Stein and Jiang saw at Dunhuang was in fact not related to the intrepid seventh-century scholar, but was rather a Chinese sutra brought to them by a young monk "of Tangutan extraction" during Stein's initial visit to the Mogao Caves on March 16, 1907. This was written on a long Chinese scroll that the young monk's Tibetan lama, who was "away on a begging tour," kept in his shrine; Stein 1912, vol. 2, 20–31; Stein 1921, vol. 2, 802.

was central.[2] As Stein put it in *Ruins of Desert Cathay*, "Chiang Ssŭ -yeh [...] loyally did his best to persuade the Tao-shih that removal of the collection to a 'temple of learning in the Ta-Ying-kuo,' or England, would in truth be an act which Buddha and his Arhats might approve as pious."[3]

Wang did not grant Stein and Jiang access to Cave Seventeen itself, but instead stationed them in a makeshift "reading room" in the adjacent Cave Sixteen, away from the eyes of curious pilgrims. There Stein and Jiang feverishly investigated bundles of manuscripts as Wang brought them out. This work lasted seven days. Being ignorant of Chinese and Tibetan, and largely unable to apply his archeological method of marking individual objects with site numbers based on their locations, Stein was both astounded at Cave Seventeen's contents and frustrated by the challenges that lack of access to the cave posed. Wang had, after all, discovered the cave seven years prior, and it was only owing to Wang's disturbing of its contents that word of the finds reached Stein in Urumchi. Stein laments the situation in *Serindia*:

> That the contents of the walled-up chapel were no longer in the order in which they had been deposited was clear. Any indications that the original position of the bundles might have afforded at the time of discovery had necessarily become effaced when the recess was cleared out in search of valuables and, later again, on the occasion of the removal of the big inscribed slab from the west wall. Even the assortment of the contents in each bundle was likely to have been often disturbed. Besides, it was mere chance in what order the Tao-shih would hand out the bundles.[4]

Stein further writes specifically about the bundles from Cave Seventeen : "[...] the first bundles which the Tao-shih brought us from it consisted of thick rolls of paper, from about 9 ½ to 10 ½ inches [24 to 27 cm] in height, evidently containing Chinese translations of canonical Buddhist texts of Chinese treatises on them."[5] These bundles were sometimes wrapped in "coarse canvas covers," some with their ends sewn up, but most with their ends left open.[6] Stein and Jiang were soon able to distinguish that there were two distinct types of bundles. "Miscellaneous bundles" were of irregular shape and contained manuscripts, paintings, "*ex-votos*," and painted fabrics, whereas "library bundles" were of a more uniform size and shape and generally contained "an average of more than a dozen separate manuscripts."[7]

2 Jiang was also instrumental in keeping Stein in the good graces of local officials, who were in the midst of political turmoil; Wang 2012, 4.

3 Stein 1912, vol. 2, 191–192.

4 Stein 1921, vol. 2, 813.

5 Stein 1921, vol. 2, 809.

6 Stein 1921, vol. 2, 823.

7 Stein 1921, vol. 2, 822; see also Stein 1912, 182–183.

Generally, the miscellaneous bundles were found on top of the piles of library bundles. The distinction between the two types of bundles is an extremely important one, and comes to bear on the meanings of the different types of site numbers, which we describe below. The vast majority of the Tibetan Dunhuang *Ap* copies came from regular "library bundles" rather than the more misshapen miscellaneous bundles of diverse objects. Stein's photograph of a pile of such library bundles (Fig. 4) includes a few bundles enclosed in canvas covers, most of which have their ends left open, just as Stein wrote.

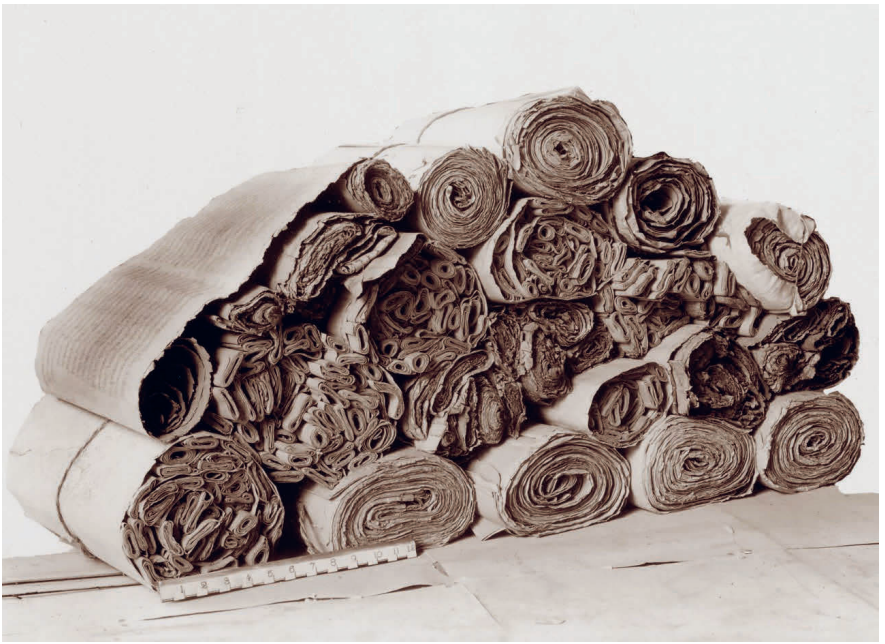


Fig. 4: Bundles of rolls from Mogao Cave Seventeen, Stein photograph 392/27(589); after Stein 1912, vol. 2, figure 194.

This image also confirms Stein's observation that there are more than a dozen "manuscripts" in each bundle. Here, however, we must clarify that by "manuscript" Stein was referring to rolls that could be very long, and that some bundles contained up to sixty rolls. Stein elsewhere refers to a stack of such rolls that were placed on top of one another and then rolled up together using the now archaic-sounding noun "convolute": "I soon ascertained that the solid mass of 'library bundles' still left in the chapel contained also a considerable proportion of packets with

large convolutes of Tibetan sheets usually divided into six columns (Ch. 05, Plate CLXXIII)."[8] This describes the usual format of a Tibetan *Ap* roll, which consists of six columns of text spread over three panels of paper (see Fig. 1, above). One can see from the lower right image in Stein's plate 173 that he was indeed referring to a "convolute" – or bundle – of Tibetan *Ap* copies (Fig. 5).



Fig. 5: Photograph of a stack of *SP2* folia (above), and one of the "convolutes" or "library bundles" (lower right) from Mogao Cave Seventeen (note that the scraps in the image on the lower left, "Ch.011," bear no relation to the bundle "Ch.05" to its right). The bundle is partly unrolled to show that it is a stack of Tibetan *Ap* copies that have been rolled up together; after Stein 1921, vol. 4, plate 173.

This photographic evidence of a stack of library bundles, some with canvas covers (Fig. 4), each with of over a dozen sutra rolls, and of one partly unrolled bundle of Tibetan *Ap* copies (Fig. 5) furnishes precious information that helps us to decipher the meanings of the site numbers written on these manuscripts.

8 Stein 1921, vol. 2, 816.

Due to the circumstances in which Stein and Jiang accessed these manuscripts, there was no way to mark them with site numbers in such a way as to record their initial location in Cave Seventeen. Stein mentions notes that he took at the time, and it appears that he wrote a few site numbers on the manuscripts during this period in Dunhuang, but he states that most site numbers were added later in London.[9] Somewhat helpless in the face of so much Chinese and Tibetan textual material, Stein seems to have focused on paintings and textiles, and to have tasked Jiang with cataloguing the manuscripts.

> I set the Ssŭ-yeh to work to prepare a rough list of titles; but as by and by the devout guardian of these treasures took more courage and began to drag out load after load of manuscript bundles, all attempt even at the roughest cataloguing had to be abandoned. It would have required a whole staff of learned scribes to deal properly with such a deluge.[10]

This attempt at the "roughest cataloguing" was probably carried out prior to Stein's purchase of the manuscripts from Wang on May 29, and it may not have involved Jiang writing any numbers or notes on the manuscripts themselves. Stein acquired considerably more manuscripts and objects from Wang in the second week of June, after Wang returned from a begging round, such that his entire haul consisted of over 300 paintings and embroideries, approximately ninety bundles of Chinese and Tibetan manuscripts, and other items, all packed away into sixteen or seventeen cases.[11] To this Jiang added a massive additional purchase of 220 to 230 bundles of Chinese and Tibetan sutras, which he acquired from Wang in October.[12]

All of these manuscripts were eventually packed together in crates from June 19 to July 18, 1908, and shipped to London. Prior to and during the packing of these crates, while Jiang and Stein were together in Khotan, Jiang wrote numbers and notes on the versos of over a thousand of these Dunhuang manuscripts, mostly Chinese sutras. Stein stated that at that time, Jiang was able to make "a first rapid listing of less than a third" of the manuscripts in the "regular" or "library" bundles comprising primarily textual material.[13]

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9 Stein 1921, vol. 2, 828–829. See the helpful documentation in Terzi and Whitfield 2024, 62, which uses Stein's notes to specify which manuscripts and objects he consulted on each day from May 23 to May 28.

10 Stein 1912, vol. 2, 175.

11 Terzi and Whitfield 2024, 60 and 73, n. 25.

12 Terzi and Whitfield 2024, 60.

13 Stein 1921, vol. 2, 916. For further details about Jiang's work during this time, see Terzi and Whitfield 2024, 63.



Fig. 6: Jiang Xiaowan at the end of Stein's second expedition, Khotan, July 31, 1908. The British Library, photograph 392/26(831).



Fig. 7: A Chinese roll from Dunhuang bearing Jiang Xiaowan's numbering, "759," and title, *Lie guo zhuan*; after Stein 1921, vol. 4, plate 166. Now pressmark S.328.

The upper right of the image shows that Jiang numbered the manuscript's verso using what are known as Suzhou numerals 蘇州碼子 or Huama 花碼, a numeral system employed during the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries.[14] Jiang added such numbers, along with titles and brief notes, to over 1,300 Chinese Dunhuang manuscripts – including over a dozen copies of the Chinese *Ap*. Many have Arabic numbers adjacent, presumably added later to translate Jiang's numbers. The first manuscript that Jiang numbered was S.823, a 472-cm roll of the *Sutra of the Buddhas' Names* (*Fo ming jing* 佛名經). Only rarely did Jiang number or annotate a Tibetan manuscript.[15]

Only a few of Stein's plates follow Jiang's numbers, whereas his other images of Dunhuang manuscripts employ a different sort of site number. Stein's plate 173 (Fig. 5) captions the stack of leaves from a Tibetan *pothī*-format *Perfection of Wisdom Sutra* copy scribed at Dunhuang (henceforth *SP2*) with "Ch. 01," and captions the large bundle (Stein's "convolute") of Tibetan *Ap* rolls with "Ch. 05." Ch. 01 now bears the pressmarks ITJ 104 and ITJ 105. The site number "Ch. 05" was replaced with the site number 78.VII, as noted in the concordance at the end of La Vallée Poussin's catalogue.[16] It included sixty rolls of Tibetan *Ap* copies. The roll at one end of this bundle, transformed into its final booklet, is now assigned the pressmark ITJ 310.683, and its verso bears both Stein's old site number, found inside an India Office Library stamp, and a newer one, written to its left (Fig. 8). This replacement of Stein's rather less specific site number with a more precise site number would have taken place in London or Cambridge in the 1910s, as described below.

We find useful information about the early site numbers elsewhere in Stein's *Serindia*. In the appendices to volume 3, Stein includes provisional cataloguers' entries for all of the texts in his plates. He asked F.W. Thomas to provide data on the manuscripts in plate 173 based on the catalogue that Thomas had commissioned La Vallée Poussin to produce.[17] The information there agrees with Stein's numbers,

14 Galambos 2020, 48.

15 An exception appears to be the Tibetan manuscript ITJ 1736, which includes two sets of Jiang numbers and a note. Additionally, a curator's slip kept with ITJ 130 consists of two Jiang numbers and his note, along with a horizontal note in a different hand that states, by way of explanation, "with CXXII." It is unclear why this slip should be included with this manuscript, which bears the site number "Ch.0010."

16 La Vallée Poussin 1962, 289.

17 This is Appendix I, which is described as follows: "Notes on specimens of Tibetan manuscripts from Ch'ien-fo-tung, reproduced in plates CLXXIII, CLXXIV by F. W. Thomas, M.A., Ph.D. librarian of the India Office from the catalogue prepared by L. de La Vallee Poussin professor at the university of Ghent"; Stein 1921, vol. 3, 1470.

i.e. “Ch. 01” and “Ch. 05.”[18] Stein clarified the meaning of his site numbers or “site marks” in a footnote in the preface to *Serindia*.

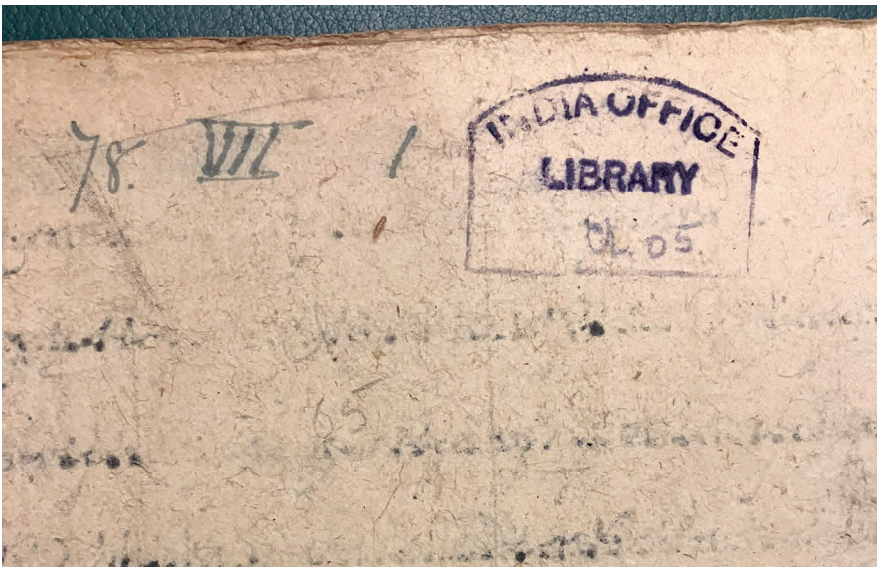


Fig. 8: Verso of ITJ 310.683, showing Stein’s initial site number, “Ch.05,” and the more specific site number, “78.VII.1”; photographed by Brandon Dotson, courtesy of the British Library.

> “Site-marks” given at the time of discovery show the initial letter of the site, the number of the ruin, etc., followed by plain Arabic figures, e.g. N. xxiv. viii. 35. In such cases these last figures correspond to the actual sequence of “finds.” When ‘site-mark’ numbers were given by myself at the site, but after the day’s work, they are preceded by a zero, e.g. L.A. vi. ii. 061. When objects had been marked by me merely with the place of discovery and numbers were subsequently added at the time of unpacking at the British Museum, two zeros precede the numbers, e.g. M. I. iv. 003.[19]

This does not necessarily shed light on site numbers like “Ch. 01” and “Ch. 05,” where “Ch.” indicates the site *Ch’ien-fo tung* (Pinyin: *Qianfo dong* 千佛洞), that is, the “Cave of One Thousand Buddhas” at Mogao. Stein’s remarks acknowledge that some “site marks” were not assigned when objects were discovered, but rather when they were unpacked at the British Museum. Apparently the majority of the

18 Stein 1921, vol. 3, 1470.
19 Stein 1921, vol. 1, xv, n. 16.

Tibetan Dunhuang *Ap* copies were assigned site numbers at this later time, by Stein's assistants. Still other rolls were not given site numbers until later, when they were kept at Cambridge University Library. Their situation was not unlike that of Stein and Jiang trying to make sense of the contents of Cave Seventeen one bundle at a time in May 1907, in the sense that Stein's assistants were also documenting manuscripts one bundle at a time as they unpacked them from crates in the basement of the British Museum or in Cambridge. Of course they did so with the benefit of more time to work and to devise sound methods of documentation.

1.2 Site numbers in London

Stein's crates of manuscripts arrived at the British Museum in January 1909, where they were kept in a portion of the museum's basement as a separate collection with its own set of keys. Of the ninety or so crates that arrived there, about thirty of them were full of manuscripts.[20] Stein's chief assistant, Fred Andrews (1866–1957), oversaw the manuscripts and objects until his departure for Kashmir in 1913. This duty then fell to Florence Lorimer (1883–1967) until she also left for Kashmir in October 1919.[21] The basement where the manuscripts and objects were kept and documented, which Stein affectionately referred to as "our old cave" or "the Beehive," was effectively "the Stein Collection" until the objects and manuscripts were divided between the British Museum and the India Office Library, beginning in 1914.

Fred Andrews oversaw the unpacking of the crates and the documentation of their contents. He was assisted initially by the archeologist Hugh Gerard Evelyn-White and by Lena Macdonald, who were tasked with producing and typing up catalogue slips for each object. By October 1909, they were joined by John Percival Droop (1882–1963) and by Florence Lorimer, who replaced Lena Macdonald.[22] A variety of other people were enlisted to catalogue and document the manuscripts and objects of the Stein Collection. Lionel Giles (1845–1935) began cataloguing the Chinese manuscripts in earnest in 1919.[23] A.H. Francke (1870–1930) and F.W. Thomas (1867–1956) were the first to catalogue and document the Tibetan manuscripts, followed by Caroline Mary Ridding (1862–1941) and Louis de La Vallée Poussin (1869–1938). Ridding commenced cataloguing by August 1910 in Cambridge, where much of the Tibetan collection was sent. This was continued together with La Vallée Poussin

20 Mirsky 1977, 306.
21 Wang 1998, 216–217.
22 Wang 1998, 209–216.
23 Giles 1957, ix; Sims-Williams 2012, 6.

from 1914 until he returned to Belgium in 1918.[24] Stein also had crates of Chinese and Tibetan manuscripts shipped to Paul Pelliot (1878–1945) in Paris and to Berthold Laufer (1874–1934) in Chicago, respectively, but with equally unfruitful results.[25]

The slow pace of cataloguing of these manuscripts was a great disappointment to Stein, and neither Giles's catalogue of the Chinese manuscripts (1957) nor La Vallée Poussin's catalogue of the Tibetan manuscripts (1962) appeared before Stein's death in 1943. La Vallée Poussin recorded the site numbers of each of the manuscripts in his catalogues of Tibetan Dunhuang manuscripts, but Giles did not do so for his catalogue of Chinese Dunhuang manuscripts. Judging from their printed catalogues, the existing online catalogue, and the evidence of the site numbers themselves documented below, it is clear that most – but not all – of these numbers were assigned before the collections were split between the British Museum, which received mostly the manuscripts in Chinese, and the India Office Library, which mostly received the manuscripts in Central Asian languages. That decision to split the collection was made in 1914, and it took some time to sort out and accomplish.

Some site numbers may have been written onto the manuscripts by Stein himself while he was in Europe from January 1909 to December 1911, in part to work on the collection.[26] However, Stein was largely engaged with writing, lecturing, and vacationing, and so most likely instructed Andrews – himself a trained archeologist whom Stein referred to affectionately as "the Baron" – about assigning site numbers.[27] This would have left the work of assigning site numbers to Andrews and to Stein's other assistants, notably Lorimer – whom Stein called the "recording angel." A passage from a letter Stein sent to Andrews, dated Nov. 20, 1909, is suggestive of such a delegation of labor: "As thing are, the best course is for you to guide Droop and Miss L. by the light of your own experience & keenness & leave to *them* as much of the drudgery as you possibly can, and to reserve for yourself the really novel tasks, such as the silks and large frescoes."[28]

Stein already established that the original disposition of the manuscripts and bundles had been thoroughly disturbed prior to his own disarranging of Cave Seventeen's contents in 1907. Unpacking the crates in London in 1909, Stein and his assistants would have had only the bundles to guide them, along with the numbers assigned to the twenty-five crates in which the manuscripts arrived. According to Stein's packing list, the manuscripts were packed in the crates numbered sixty-seven

24 Wang and Perkins 2008, 37; Stein 1921, vol. 2, 919.

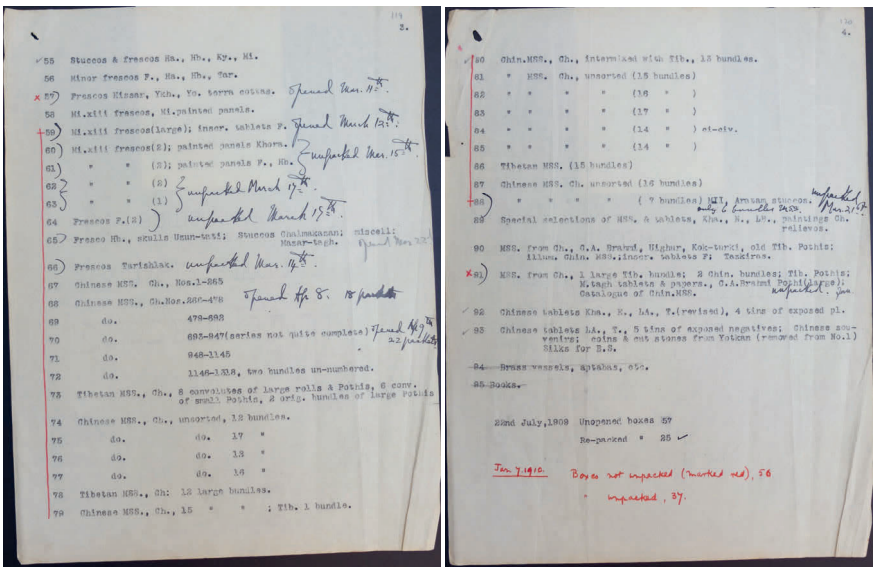
25 Sims-Williams 2012.

26 Wang and Perkins 2008, 48.

27 On Stein's activities at this time, see Mirsky 1977, 326 and Walker 1995, 187–189.

28 Bodleian Stein Manuscript 37/225, quoted in Wang 1998, 209; emphasis original.

to ninety-one, and the list mentions the number of bundles in each crate. Unpacking the crates in London, Fred Andrews made a note on the packing list, dated July 22, 1909, to say that fifty-seven crates remained unopened, and that twenty-five had been repacked. A further note, dated January 7, 1910, stated that thirty-seven crates were unpacked and that fifty-six crates were not unpacked. The latter are annotated on the list in red pen, and include nearly all of the crates in which the manuscripts were contained.[29] This could indicate that some of these crates were not unpacked before being sent to Cambridge.



Figs 9a and 9b: Final two pages of Stein's packing list, "Contents of antique cases packed June 19th–July 18th, 1908," giving the contents of each crate shipped to London; MSS Stein 37/119 and MSS Stein 37/120, courtesy of the Bodleian Library.

A comparison of Stein's packing list with existing site numbers confirms that Stein's assistants in London employed the crate numbers for assigning site numbers to the manuscripts. This is evident from the correspondence of the number of bundles in Stein's list to the number of bundles that La Vallée Poussin catalogued. To give just one example, in crate eighty-six Stein lists "Tibetan mss. (15 bundles)" and the concordance in La Vallée Poussin's catalogue similarly records fifteen bundles of

29 Terzi and Whitfield 2024, 64.

manuscripts that begin with the number eighty-six, e.g. site numbers 86.I to 86.XV.[30] There are similar correspondences for the other crates. This, together with photographic evidence and an investigation of over a thousand site numbers written on the *Ap* copies themselves, permits us to decipher the precise points of reference of certain site numbers that have up until now remained imperfectly understood.

There is a variety of site numbers, only some of which follow Stein's stated methods. Another of Stein's footnotes, regarding the site numbers on Brāhmī manuscripts from Dunhuang, is helpful for clarifying his general logic.

> [Brāhmī manuscripts] in miscellaneous bundles can be distinguished from those which were extracted from regular packets of Chinese rolls by the bundle number in small Roman figures (ii,ii xl, etc.) prefixed to the serial numbers (003, 0019, etc.) in the 'site marks'. Pōthī [sic] leaves and rolls subsequently recovered on searching the regular packets in which they were embedded bear only serial numbers (e.g. Ch.0041, 00271, etc.). [...] I may note here that when the marking with serial numbers was made at the British Museum, no classification of the different objects (manuscripts, paintings, decorated fabrics, etc.) found in the same mixed bundle could be attempted.[31]

Summarizing Stein's stated method for assigning these site numbers to Brāhmī manuscripts more plainly, an object from a "miscellaneous bundle" might be "Ch.VI.003," where "VI" indicates the bundle and "003" the object within the bundle. This in fact accurately describes the site number Ch.XXXIII.003, which belongs to the *Ap* copy with the pressmark ITJ 310.1035. In contrast, a manuscript from a regular "library bundle" would be simply given a serial number, for example "Ch.0041," with apparently nothing to indicate the bundle from which it was extracted, and no indication of how many other manuscripts there were in that regular library bundle. This corresponds to a site number such as Ch.05, which, as we have seen, labeled the entire bundle of sixty *Ap* rolls displayed in Fig. 5.

This stated method would create a profound asymmetry with respect to how manuscripts from the regular "library bundles" of rolls and other types of manuscripts were marked (e.g. "Ch.0041") in contrast to the more detailed site numbers (e.g. "Ch.VI.003") assigned to objects from the "miscellaneous bundles" that included manuscripts, painted scrolls, and other objects. Considering Stein's statement in light of the evidence of the site numbers written on the manuscripts themselves, it is happily the case that the situation on the ground is not so unfortunate as the one Stein described. In fact, more or less the same method that Stein stated above for

30 See Terzi and Whitfield 2024, 64–65. The packing list in question is kept in Stein's papers at the Bodleian Library, MSS Stein 37/117–120. Frances Wood has also written about the use of crate numbers for numbering the manuscripts; Wood 2012, 2.

31 Stein 1921, vol. 2, 814, n. 2.

numbering "miscellaneous bundles" was applied to manuscripts from "library bundles." The main difference is that in the latter case the first number given in Arabic numerals is the crate number, a point we have already established above with recourse to Stein's inventory. Just as in a site number for an object from a miscellaneous bundle like "Ch.XXXIII.003" where the "003" refers to the third item within bundle "XXXIII," so too in a site number for an object from a regular library bundle – almost always a roll – like "Ch.73.III.5," the "5" refers to the fifth roll within bundle "III" taken from crate seventy-three.[32] It is chiefly the crate number at the start of these site numbers for regular library bundles that distinguishes them from those used for miscellaneous bundles. The reliance on the crate number also permitted some laziness, since sometimes an entire bundle was given a number such as 86.X without numbering its rolls individually, e.g. 86.X.1, etc.

The bundle numbers were presumably assigned according to the order in which Stein's assistants removed the bundles from a crate to document them. From Fred Andrews's tally of either unopened crates or repacked crates, one can assume that bundles were returned to their crates after being assigned site numbers. This explanation of such site numbers perfectly describes the state of the site numbers assigned to both the Tibetan and Chinese Dunhuang *Ap* copies in the Stein Collection, and constitutes a sound method for documenting the bundles such as we see them in the images above (Figs 4 and 5), since one can number the dozen or so bundles that emerged from each crate without risk of confusing, for example, bundle 79.II with bundle 80.II, or roll 73.IX.5 with roll 75.IX.5. This demonstrates how these site numbers are only made possible with the addition of the crate number. It also shows how Stein and/or his assistants devised a system that in fact followed Stein's logic to add some precision to the earlier site numbers by working with relevant objects at hand, namely crates, bundles, and rolls.

In this common type of site number that includes three numbers, e.g. "73.III.5," the prefix "Ch.," indicating the site's name, has often been elided. Stein's practice was to place spaces between these numbers and to use lowercase Roman numerals, but Stein's assistants, curators, and cataloguers have tended to dispense with the spaces and to use uppercase Roman numerals, as we do here.

It is obvious that a site number like "Ch.05" is inferior to a site number like "78.VII.1," which is able to indicate crate number, bundle number, and roll number. It is less obvious how curators were able to replace the former with the latter. One possibility is that at some point during those seven days sorting through manuscripts and objects in May 1907, Stein or Jiang handled this bundle, and assigned the

32 Takeuchi came close to this solution, but mistook the initial number, e.g. seventy-three, for the bundle number rather than the crate number; Takeuchi 2012, 209–210.

number Ch. 05 to it and/or to one of its rolls. Following Stein's protocols for using zeros, this *might* indicate that this was done at the end of a day in May 1907 in Dunhuang, rather than during the day itself or a year later in Khotan or two or more years later in London. If this were the case, then this roll on which Stein wrote the site number must have been returned to the bundle from which it came, since the more detailed site numbers that identified it as bundle VII from crate seventy-eight were necessarily only assigned after the crates were unpacked in London in 1909.

From Stein's account of their work during these seven days, it is clear that Wang first brought out only a few manuscripts and objects from Cave Seventeen, and then brought manuscripts and objects in progressively larger amounts. This process of "lending" out the manuscripts in ever larger units, and then collecting them again at the end of each day, would disarrange those bundles and items that Stein and Jiang consulted. In fact, Ch.05 is one of the few such site numbers of this type (e.g. "Ch.07") and of a similar type (e.g. "Ch. 0025") to be replaced with more detailed (e.g. "Ch.79.IX.5") site numbers. Dozens of others, like Ch. 08 and Ch. 0066, were never replaced with more detailed site numbers, perhaps because they could not be reliably linked to the library bundle or miscellaneous bundle from which Wang, Stein, or Jiang had separated them. While conjectural, this hypothesis offers a plausible account of the meanings of the main types of site numbers, and some hints about how and when they were produced.[33]

It is very helpful to know that site numbers like 73.III.5 indicate crate number, bundle number, and roll number in "library bundles," whereas a number like XXXIII.003 indicates bundle number and item number in a miscellaneous bundle. This allows one to fully appreciate the advantage of these site numbers, as imperfect as they are, and how they offer scholars another way to navigate the Stein collection. Doing so, one can discover relationships between manuscripts and objects that were and are catalogued and conserved apart from one another, and sometimes at different institutions, e.g. the British Museum and the British Library. In Appendix Two we gesture further towards this approach by pointing out the contours of each bundle in terms of its contents and how they were documented.[34]

There are many instances where different types of site numbers are found alongside one another, revealing an "archeology" of documentation and conservation. The Jiang numbers – and perhaps Stein numbers such as "Ch.05" – are the

33 Others, such as Ch.06 and Ch.011, which both became site number Ch.86.IV, can be found in La Vallée Poussin's concordance, published at the end of his posthumous catalogue; La Vallée Poussin 1962, 289. For discussions of the various types of site numbers, see Takuechi 2012b, 209–212 and Terzi and Whitfield 2024, 61–68.

34 See also the attempt to reconstruct a few bundles in Terzi and Whitfield 2024, 78–82.

earliest stratum, and they appear on many Chinese manuscripts that are catalogued as having no site number. They also appear alongside site numbers assigned later. In this regard they are not alone; examples of both types of site numbers that Stein described occur in the upper margin of Or.8212/83, a manuscript fragment with Chinese on the recto and Sogdian on the verso (Fig. 10). There one reads "Ch.00334" and, in a separate hand using different ink, "82.XVI." Presumably Stein or an assistant wrote the first number, and the second number was added once the practice of numbering items by crate and bundle had been settled, and when this manuscript could still be reliably provenanced to bundle 82.XVI.

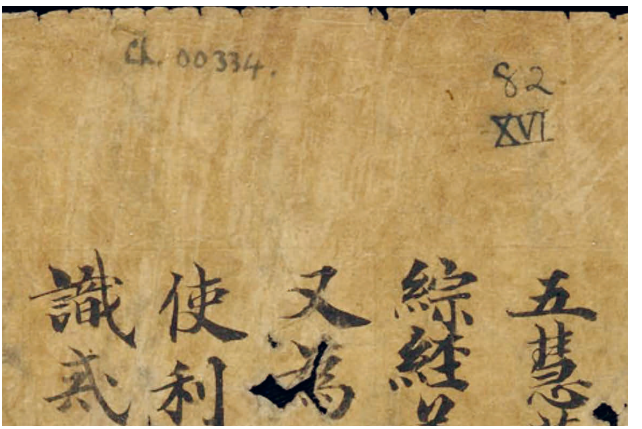
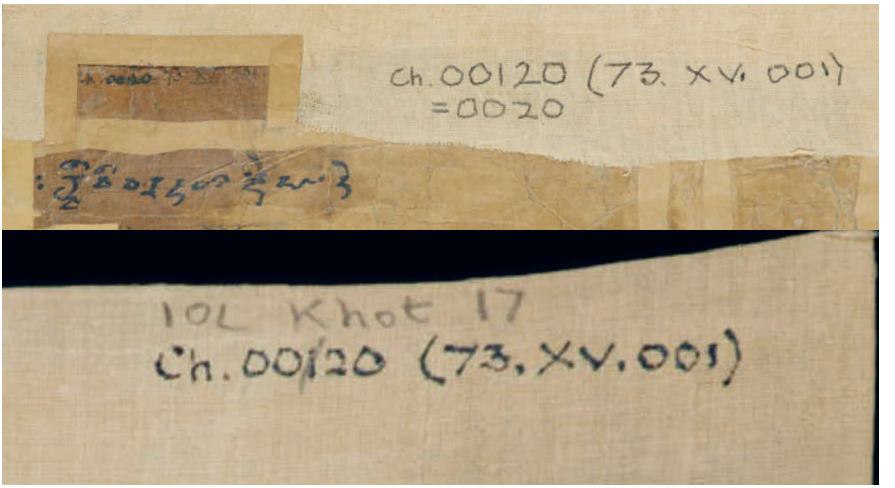


Fig. 10: Or.8212/83 recto, showing two site numbers; image captured by the authors from http://idp.bl.uk/, courtesy of the British Library.

The same situation is found on the verso of a fragmentary Tibetan *Ap* copy. This was apparently taken from bundle 73.XV, which also contains a few other Tibetan *Ap* copies, among other manuscripts. It was then catalogued for the Khotanese content on its verso and assigned the pressmark IOL Khot S 17 (Fig. 11). As in the previous case, two separate hands in two separate inks wrote the two site numbers, "Ch.0020" and "73.XV.001" (Fig. 11a, upper left corner). Later curators wrote on the mounting gauze to clarify that the one number is equated with the other (Fig. 11a, upper right; Fig. 11b). As before, Stein or someone else first extracted this manuscript from a regular bundle and gave it a number in keeping with his statement quoted above, and then Stein or an assistant then apparently improved upon this by specifying the number of the bundle it had originally been extracted from, and the number of the crate in which it was packed. It is not surprising that this is rare,

since such "extraction" is likely to orphan a manuscript from its bundle unless there is a note attached, or unless it was carefully put back in place in its bundle.



Figs 11a and 11b: IOL Khot S 17 verso, showing two site numbers; image captured by the authors from http://idp.bl.uk/, courtesy of the British Library.

Stein and his assistants typically assigned site numbers at the level of the object. In the case of the manuscripts considered here, this is true whether the object was a fragment of a roll, a 135 cm-long roll containing one sutra copy, or a twenty-meter-long roll containing fifteen sutra copies. The task of going through thousands of manuscripts in these crates and bundles and writing a site number on each roll proved to be impractical, however, perhaps nowhere more so than in the case of the 1,055 rolls of Tibetan *Ap* copies that emerged from Stein's crates. Consequently, and possibly as a result of the work of various different hands – Stein's, Andrews's, Lorimer's, and others – a variety of methods arose by which the site numbers were added. Here we describe a few of these.

Having removed a bundle from a crate in order to assign site numbers, Stein or one of Stein's assistants would be faced with a rather unwieldy task. The bundle might be made up of single-sutra rolls, each 135 to 160 cm long, which had been unrolled, stacked on top of one another and then rolled up as a bundle. To unroll this bundle and to separate each roll in order to number them individually would be to risk damaging the rolls. It would also be to clutter one's workspace with fifty or so rolls, since a bundle contains between seventeen and sixty-four rolls, and each

roll would naturally spring back into its rolled position if its ends were not weighted down. An enlarged image of the bundle that Stein dubbed "Ch.05" is instructive. Here one can see the disposition of the bundle. The sutra copy that Stein made visible for the picture by partially unrolling the bundle would be on top of the stack of flat sutras if the bundle were fully unrolled.[35] In fact, when they fully unrolled the bundle Stein's assistants found another sutra copy adjacent to this one, and that copy – ITJ 310.683, pictured above in Fig. 8 – was assigned a site number as the first roll in the bundle, 78.VII.1. There were no doubt other such discoveries and surprises within these bundles once they were unrolled, and this would be one of the main reasons for unrolling each bundle.

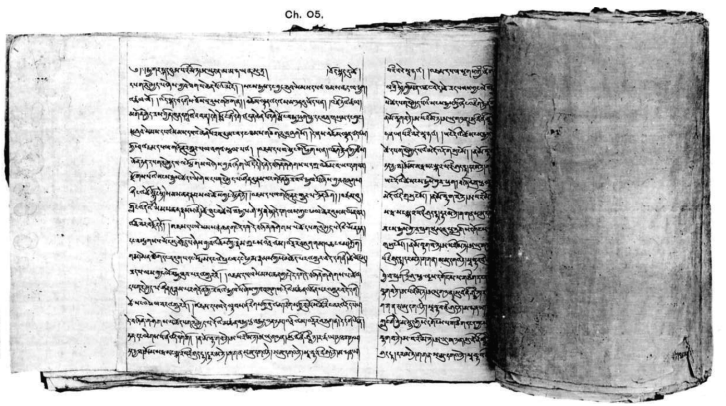


Fig. 12: Detail of one of the "library bundles" from Mogao Cave Seventeen; after Stein 1921, vol. 4, plate 173.

These bundles were also quite messy. The bundle pictured above, 78.VII, contained forty-eight single-sutra rolls each measuring about 135 cm, four two-sutra rolls each measuring about 180 cm, three three-sutra rolls each measuring about 225 cm, one four-sutra roll measuring about 270 cm, and four five-sutra rolls each measuring about 315 cm. As a stack of rolls, it would have a thick, 135-cm "body," and a long, thin 315-cm "tail." This state of affairs also explains how rolls of single-sutra copies might lay adjacent to one another within a bundle, only to be discovered when the bundle was fully unrolled. In this and other such bundles, the rolls of varying lengths were not stacked neatly according to the length of each roll, e.g. longest to

35 This is ITJ 310.682, which is now the second to last booklet in the stack of booklets in Vol. 106.

shortest or vice-versa, before being rolled up together as a bundle. Additionally, the sutra copies were not necessarily all stacked on top of one another right-side up when they were rolled into bundles. This is evident from at least two facts. First, damage from water or another fluid affected all twenty-four of the rolls in bundle 86.XIII, and this is more apparent in the last few rolls than it is in the first few rolls, no doubt because of how the bundle was rolled up.[36] However, this damage is visible in the top margins of some sutra copies, and in the bottom margins of others, which means that they were not all stacked in the same direction with respect to their contents. Second, the sutra copies in bundle 86.X have this site number in black ink written either on the verso of the first panel or on the verso of the last panel, which is to say, either on the front cover or the back cover of their booklets (Fig. 15, below). This would happen were one to number a bundle of rolls without arranging them such that they are all oriented the same way, that is, without attending to the fact that some were rotated 180 degrees with respect to the others. It might also suggest that this work was done by assistants and curators who treated these rolls as objects without attending to the direction of writing.

Given that Wang, Stein, and Jiang may have disturbed these bundles of rolls prior to their being documented in London, we cannot necessarily assume that this order of rolls reflected the bundle's original state as it was deposited in Cave Seventeen. Nor, for that matter, can we conclude with certainty that this order reflected these sutra copies' manner of storage in the Dunhuang temple libraries of Longxing si, Sanjie si and others prior to their being deposited in Cave Seventeen. However, a close examination of these bundles and their rolls of sutras, as described in Chapter Three, reveals a high degree of internal coherence at the level of the bundle that strongly suggests that most bundles were in fact largely untouched after they were rolled up. It was apparently only during the later stages of their conservation in Cambridge and London that the order of rolls became inverted or shuffled, but even this, as we will see, was rare. This is important to the context of these manuscripts' use, since it suggests that they were mainly copied to be kept or "deposited" for the merit that they created. It may also be the case that these manuscripts' ubiquity, and the comparatively low doxographical status of the *Sutra of Limitless Life*, also accounts for their relatively undisturbed state prior to conservation in London.

If Stein or his assistants were to have separated each roll from the other rolls in its bundle, then they would have faced the issue of whether to store these separately, as individual rolls, or whether to roll them back up as they were, in a bundle, without damaging them or disturbing their sequence. The sixty rolls of bundle

36 This makes it less likely – though not impossible – that the damage occurred after they were bound as booklets.

78.VII (pictured in Fig. 12) would have been even more unwieldy and more prone to damage as separate objects than as rolls within a bundle. In this case, someone wrote the site number "78.VII.1" on first, that is the top, roll in the bundle. They neglected to number the rolls below this one, only numbering the bottom roll in the bundle "78.VII." The fifty-eight rolls between these two rolls have no site numbers at all. This suggests a cursory "first pass," probably in the Beehive, that did not involve separating the rolls individually from their bundle. It also implies that these rolls were meant to be assigned serial site numbers based on the model of the first number assigned, i.e. 78.VII.1 to 78.VII.60. In the end, nobody ever completed this task, and fifty-eight of this bundle's sixty rolls went without site numbers.



Fig. 13: ITJ 310.1149 on its side, rotated ninety degrees – in faded red ink one can read "Ch.73.XI.19," adjacent, in pencil, is a "3," indicating the number of sutras in this multiple-sutra roll, and in the left of the image (top right of the booklet), a reduplication of the site number is written in pencil, perpendicular to the faded red site number; photographed by Brandon Dotson, courtesy of the British Library.

In other bundles it is clear that someone did what was apparently intended for bundle 78.VII by assigning serial site numbers to every roll in a bundle. For example, the twenty-eight rolls in bundle 73.XI have site numbers written onto their versos in red ink, which has since faded to pink (Fig. 13). Duplicate site numbers in pencil, perpendicular to these, were presumably added once the ink had faded to illegibility. Both sets of site numbers proceed serially, from 73.XI.1 to 73.XI.28. The site numbers are written on the verso of the beginning of each roll, which would have been the available outside surface of each roll in the bundle if it were barely unrolled for numbering purposes and to check it for other manuscripts or objects. Thus site numbers may have been assigned to each of this bundle's twenty-eight rolls without fully unrolling them, or at least without separating the rolls individually from one another.

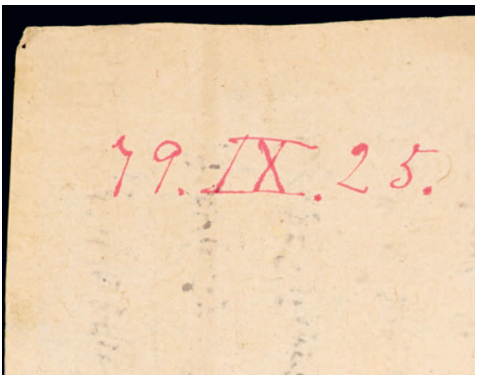


Fig. 14: Site number 79.IX.25 on the verso of S.2018, a Chinese Ap copy; image captured by the authors from http://idp.bl.uk/, courtesy of the British Library.

We find a similar situation when examining the Chinese Dunhuang *Ap* copies kept at the British Library. Like the Tibetan *Ap* rolls, these rolls are also of varying lengths: some rolls contain a single *Ap* copy and other rolls contain multiple *Ap* copies. These rolls also came from regular "library bundles," some of which they shared with Tibetan *Ap* rolls.[37] Those Chinese rolls with the site number 79.IX are numbered in red pen using the serial method, as in the case of those Tibetan rolls with site number 73.XI, also in red ink. The numbers run from 79.IX.1 to at least 79.IX.37.[38] They are similarly written on the verso of the beginning of each roll, as in the case of S.2018 (Fig. 14). These site numbers are not necessarily in the same hand as those on the Tibetan *Ap* copies. The writing is larger, and one also notes here the absence of the Ch. prefix on the 79.IX site numbers for these Chinese *Ap* rolls.

In the case of this bundle of Chinese *Ap* copies, which fell under the purview of the British Museum, the rolls were separated from their bundles, and each roll was stored individually in its own scroll box. As a result, hundreds of scroll boxes had to be manufactured for these and the 288 rolls or fragments of Chinese *Ap* copies in the Stein Collection. Some are long rolls with up to four *Ap* copies, while others are rolls of just one sutra copy. These are discussed in more detail in Chapter Three.

37 One example is 77.VII, a bundle that contained, among other manuscripts, one roll of Tibetan *Ap* and two rolls of Chinese *Ap*. See Appendix Two for details.

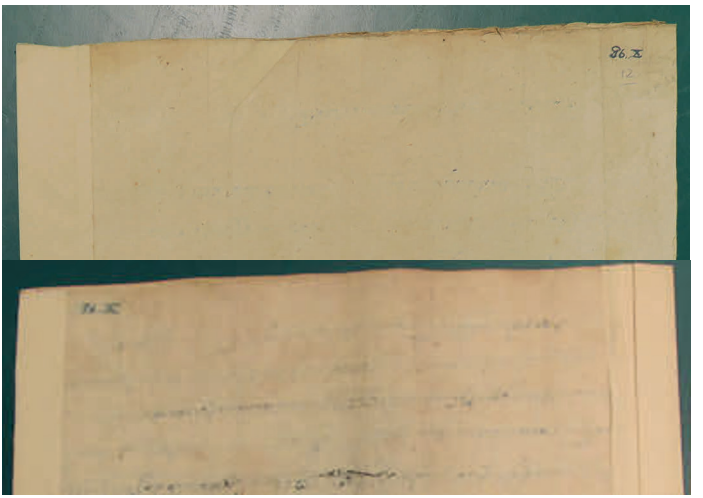
38 Terzi and Whitfield use this as one of the three bundles in their case study for reconstructing bundles based on site numbers; see Terzi and Whitfield 2024, 67–70. They commit the common mistake of conflating these *Ap* copies with copies of the *Sukhāvatīvyūha sūtra*. The two texts share the same short title in Chinese.

A more common method of assigning site numbers, which appears to have been more often used for the Tibetan manuscripts at the India Office Library than for the Chinese manuscripts at the British Museum, was to forego the serial site numbers by assigning a less precise site number that applied equally to every roll in a given bundle. This is a middle ground between the desultory method of just marking the site number on the first and last roll of a bundle, e.g. 78.VII, and the more thorough method of writing a unique serial site number on every roll, e.g. 73.XI.1 to 73.XI.28. This applies, for example, to the fifty-five single-sutra rolls of Tibetan *Ap* copies that were assigned the site number 86.X. Stein or an assistant wrote the site number "86.X" in black ink on the versos of all fifty-five rolls in this bundle (see Fig. 15). These numbers appear sometimes at the beginning of the verso and sometimes at the end. This suggests, as stated above, that when the rolls were stacked on one another and rolled into a bundle for storage in a temple library and/or in Cave Seventeen, the sutra copies were not carefully arranged with respect to their contents. Some apparently were rotated 180 degrees, and some may have lain "back-to-back" (versos touching) or "front-to-front" (rectos touching) with their neighbors. Alternatively, this could have resulted from someone consulting an *Ap* copy or otherwise disturbing the bundle, but in such cases one would assume that this would involve only the first or last roll rather than rolls in the middle of a bundle. The most convenient method was for Stein or his assistants to number the versos that were most easily accessible as they documented these manuscripts and made inventories of each bundle. This likely accounts for why the site number "86.X" is found either on the beginning or end of the verso, which is to say the front cover or back cover of the booklets kept in Vol. 95 (Figs 15a and 15b).[39]

This type of site numbering, which does not add serial site numbers to each roll within a bundle, also appears on some Chinese *Ap* copies, again in black ink. On S.492 and S.503, for example, the site number 86.I is written in black ink on the verso of the end of each roll. This agrees perfectly with the method of assigning site numbers to the Tibetan rolls at 86.X, and it is perhaps notable that both bundles come from the same crate, number eighty-six.

In these few examples, we can already see a lack of uniformity with regard to the location of the site numbers on the manuscripts, the color of ink used to write them, and the method of assigning them. Concerning the latter, we observe that those rolls with site number 73.XI all bear serial site numbers, e.g. 73.XI.1 through 73.XI.29, rather than simply all sharing the same site number of 73.XI. Of the twenty-six site numbers – which is to say twenty-six bundles – that include several rolls of

39 Additional photographic documentation of site number 86.X appears in Fig. 2, where "86.X" bleeds through from the verso, as well as Figs 3, 19, 20, 23a, and 24.



Figs 15a and 15b: Site numbers 86.X written on the verso of the start of ITJ 310.256 (upper right of front cover of the booklet, spine to the left) and on the verso of the end of ITJ 310.253 (upper left of back cover of the booklet, spine to the right). Note booklet number "12" in pencil below the site number in Fig. 15a; photographed by Brandon Dotson, courtesy of the British Library.

Tibetan *Ap* copies, only five employ these serial site numbers that distinguish the specific number of each roll. The other four are Ch.73.XVI (Vol. 113), Ch.73.XVII (Vol. 114), Ch.73.IX (Vol. 117), and Ch.73.X (Vol. 118). These are split evenly between bundles of single-sutra rolls and bundles that also include multiple-sutra rolls, the specifics of which are treated in Chapter Three.

These various methods are not necessarily the result of unitary norms that degraded over time from the more thorough to the cursory. Rather, they appear to have resulted from different standards applied by different assistants and curators. These tend to cohere not only at the level of the bundle, but also at the level of the crate, which suggests that different people (e.g. La Vallée Poussin, Ridding) were assigned different crates to go through and number. All of the many Tibetan *Ap* copies from the bundles in crates seventy-eight and eighty-six, for example, use the less specific type of site number, and this is written in black ink. By contrast, all of the Tibetan *Ap* copies from the bundles in crate seventy-three have the more specific site numbers, and these are written in red ink. As we will see, it appears that these latter, specific site numbers were the work of C.M. Ridding in Cambridge.

A few Tibetan *Ap* copies have different site numbers that tell us nothing of their locations within crates or bundles. This is true of those labeled "Fragments." Confusingly, some of these are complete sutra copies (e.g. Fragment 41, pressmark

ITJ 310.422), while others are indeed fragments of sutra copies (e.g. Fragment 53.5, pressmark ITJ 310.427). It is unclear why these complete sutra copies were designated as fragments.

There is also a sequence of *Ap* copies, pressmarks ITJ 1588 to ITJ 1615 – excluding ITJ 1601 –, that have simple site numbers consisting only of Arabic numerals and without the Ch prefix. These amount to twenty-two manuscripts and fragments numbered 10, 13, 14, 23, 34, 35, 36, 44, 45, 46, 47, 48, 49, 50, 51, 52, 53, 54, 55, 56, 57, 58. Their skips in sequence, e.g. from 36 to 44, appear to be a recognition of existing manuscripts that bear intervening numbers prefixed by "Fragment," e.g. "Fragment 41," mentioned just above. These numbers are often in pencil, alongside the number 310, the latter written in pen, probably by La Vallée Poussin. It is not necessarily the case that the word "Fragment" was elided from these penciled numbers, since we find Fragment 44, Fragment 49, and Fragment 52 – which overlap with the unprefixed numbers 44, 49, and 52 just given above – as site numbers assigned to non-*Ap* manuscripts at pressmarks ITJ 109, ITJ 120, and ITJ 256, respectively, in La Vallée Poussin's concordance.[40]

The numbers on these manuscripts represent an anomaly. Since they are not found in La Vallée Poussin's inventory of site numbers, nor in his catalogue's concordance, they were likely added after his cataloguing work, which is to say after World War I. If one assumes the concordance to be the work of A.F. Thompson, then these numbers were also probably unknown in the early 1960s. Examining these manuscripts in more detail, it becomes clear that these are only "quasi-site numbers," that have resulted from confusion during the process of documenting these manuscripts and assigning site numbers. In other words, these are manuscripts that were quite likely mislaid, or orphaned from their bundles during the cataloguing process. In this respect they are similar to Stein's Ch.0023- and Ch. 05-type numbers, which also seem to have resulted from separating manuscripts from the regular library bundles in which they had been previously kept. One example will suffice to demonstrate this. La Vallée Poussin's catalogue lists five copies under the pressmark "Ch.i.1." However, only one *Ap* copy is now found with this site number, at pressmark ITJ 310.1034. In pencil, on the verso of column a of this copy we find written, "*aparamitayur*, 5 copies, incomplete, Ch.I.1. Part of a bundle numbered Ch.I from sorted Chinese bundles." This further corroborates La Vallée Poussin's catalogue. This copy's roll number is thirteen, and it is a copy of the "A1" version of the sutra, the details of which will be discussed in Chapter Two. Searching among the twenty-two above items with their defective, penciled quasi-site numbers, we find rolls nine, ten, eleven, and twelve, all A1 copies, strongly suggesting that they,

40 La Vallée Poussin 1962, 299.

together with roll thirteen (ITJ 310.1034), had previously constituted the five copies at Ch.I.1. These four copies bear the respective "quasi-site numbers" 54, 53, 49, and 47. Presumably, the site number "Ch.I.1" was initially added only to one of the five rolls when they were kept together, and somehow the other four were separated and mislaid.[41] These four rolls were later assigned pressmarks ITJ 1611, ITJ 310.423, ITJ 1607, and ITJ 1605, respectively.

To compound this mistake, the manuscript with the quasi-site number "53" was moved together with the four fragments and copies that La Vallée Poussin had catalogued as "Fragment 53." Someone then added decimals in pencil after each number 53, such that the five manuscripts in this newly created group proceeded "53.1" through "Fragment 53.5," thereby creating the false impression that "53" had been a part of "Fragment 53" all along. The latter site number therefore ended up having five items within it, rather than the four items that La Vallée Poussin recorded for Fragment 53 in his catalogue. In Chapter Three and Four and in Appendix Two we rectify these and other such mistakes to virtually reunite some manuscripts that had been orphaned or misassigned by the processes of conservation and cataloguing.

There are such "casualties" of the documentation process among the Chinese *Ap* copies as well. Most have consistent site numbers, and many that are listed as having no site number in fact have Jiang numbers. However, a few of them, mostly fragments, have no site numbers at all. Among those with no site numbers are the fragments S.324, S.1107, and S.1143. The complete, edited *Ap* copy S.4088 (Fig. 39) also has no site number.

Among the sutra copies and fragments that do not come from regular bundles of mostly *Ap* copies, but rather from bundles where they were mixed in among many other sorts of texts, we also find an odd variation on the more standard site numbers. Pressmarks ITJ 310.415, 416, and 418 are three complete *Ap* copies with the site number 87.XIII. To this site number was added the lower-case letters "a," "b," and "f," respectively, but these are written slightly below, suggesting they were added later, by someone who was not following the usual system that would dictate the use of Arabic numerals for serial site numbering. This type of site number (e.g.

41 Prevarication between lowercase and uppercase letters has sowed confusion concerning this site number. There are several painted scrolls and Khotanese manuscripts with the site number Ch.i, with serial numbers preceded by two zeros, e.g. Ch.i.003. Four Tibetan items, by contrast, use the upper case Ch.I, and follow this with serial numbers without zeros, e.g. Ch.I.3. The ambiguity of the uppercase I has also meant that some curators and cataloguers have (mis)read the site number as "Ch.1," that is, the Arabic number rather than the Roman numeral.

"87.XIII.d," where "d" is apparently a later addition) is visible in the image of the fragment ITJ 310.1204 in Fig. 22 below.

Later strata of numbering processes complicate matters even further. We have already shown that Stein and/or his assistants probably wrote many of these site numbers onto the manuscripts as they proceeded through their documentation of crates and bundles in the basement of the British Museum. However, it is also clear that some site numbers were added later, after the Chinese materials went to the British Museum and the Tibetan materials went to the India Office Library, beginning from 1914. This becomes evident when we approach these manuscripts at the level of the bundle. Tibetan and Chinese manuscripts from the same bundle are not always numbered using the same method. Whereas in some bundles, Tibetan and Chinese items are both marked with serial site numbers, in other bundles Chinese items are marked with serial site numbers while the Tibetan items in the same bundle are marked without them. This is true of manuscripts with site number 81.VIII, for example, whose Tibetan manuscripts are each labeled 81.VIII, whereas its Chinese manuscripts each have their own serial number, e.g. 81.VIII.7. Elsewhere, the serial site numbers of Chinese items in a bundle overlap with the serial site numbers of Tibetan items in the same bundle, which is something that presumably would not occur if the items in the bundle were numbered serially when they were kept together in the Beehive. In bundle 79.XIV, for instance, 79.XIV.3 designates both the Tibetan manuscript ITJ 310.1206 and the Chinese manuscript S.3824. This is not an isolated occurrence, and other instances where Tibetan and Chinese manuscripts from the same bundle are assigned identical site numbers are noted in Appendix Two. Such duplicate numbers, as well as the more common circumstance where Tibetan manuscripts and Chinese manuscripts from the same bundle employ less specific (non-serial) and more specific (serial) site numbering, respectively, confirms that quite a lot of site numbering was done after the Tibetan manuscripts were separated from the Chinese.

These site numbers assigned to Chinese manuscripts at the British Museum and to Tibetan manuscripts at the India Office Library diverged not only from each other, but also from the initial site numbers assigned prior to the division of the collection. In bundle 79.XIV, for example, seven of the twelve Tibetan items lack serial site numbers. It may be that Stein, Andrews, Lorimer, or another of the "Beehive" assistants added the site number "79.XIV," and that Hoernle, Ridding, or La Vallée Poussin added the more detailed serial site numbers later. An inverse situation could also apply, where someone first assigned a few detailed site numbers, and expected others to follow the model for further items, as in the case of bundle Ch.05/ 78.VII, described above. An almost identical situation describes the site numbering of the items at 79.XVI. This would suggest that up to three hands

assigned site numbers within such a bundle: one at the "Beehive" prior to the division of the collections, assigning numbers at the level of the bundle; one working on the Chinese manuscripts at the British Museum; and one working on the Tibetan manuscripts at the India Office Library or in Cambridge. Despite these rough edges, which emerge only when one examines the collection at the level of the bundle, the documentation process largely succeeded in preserving the crucial information about which manuscripts came from which bundles.

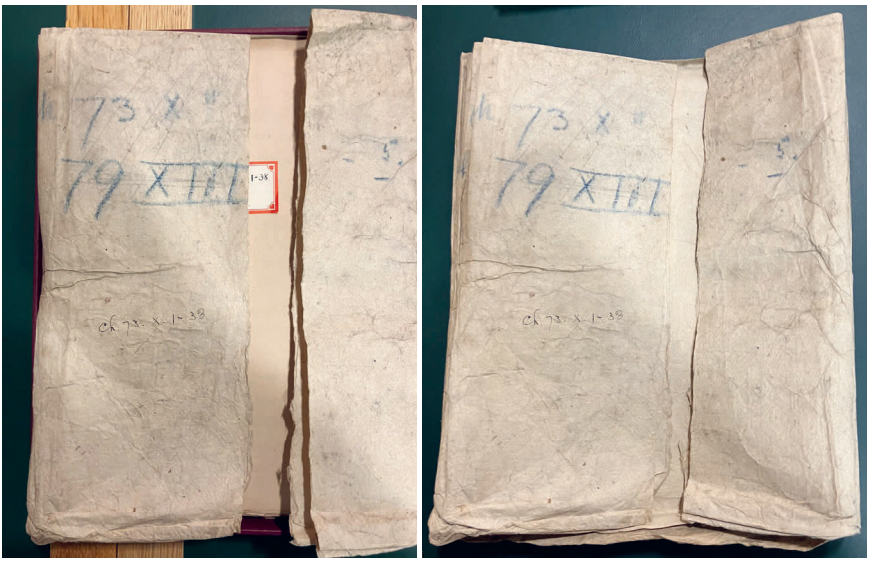
1.3 Cataloguing and preparatory work in Cambridge

F.W. Thomas was responsible for Stein's Tibetan Dunhuang manuscripts at the India Office Library in London, where he served as librarian from 1903 to 1927. He and C.M. Ridding began documenting the manuscripts in 1910, and by 1914 Thomas enlisted Louis de La Vallée Poussin, the famous Belgian Buddhologist who took refuge at Cambridge during the First World War. A letter from Stein dated July 8, 1910 refers to the deposit of Stein's Tibetan manuscripts at Cambridge University Library, and states that Ridding, who was preparing an inventory, should be permitted to work on the material at her home, "up to a maximum of three bundles."[42] La Vallée Poussin probably enjoyed similar privileges at Cambridge.

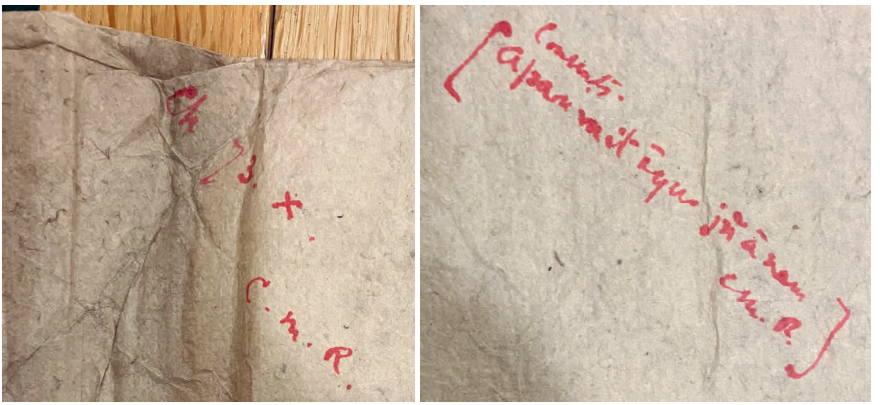
In fact, one paper wrapper bearing C.M. Ridding's handwriting is likely the original wrapping in which she transported a bundle of Dunhuang manuscripts between her home and the Cambridge University Library. It is now found in Vol. 118, together with the *Ap* copies bearing site number 73.X (Figs 16a and 16b). The wrapper was presumably conserved as an example of the type of wrapper that was used for conserving these manuscripts while they were still kept in bundles, prior to binding.

On the back of this wrapper we read, written in red ink, "Ch 73.x. C.m.R." and "[Contents aparimitāyurjñānam C.m.R.]" (Figs 16c and 16d). This confirms that C.M. Ridding used a red pen to identify the contents as part of her initial cataloguing work. The sutra copies from this bundle do in fact have the more detailed, serial site numbering in red pen. It is likely that Ridding was responsible for this more specific method of site numbering in red pen where it is found in the other four relevant bundles in crate seventy-three, as detailed above.

42 Wang and Perkins 2008, 37.



Figs 16a and 16b: Paper wrapping in which the Tibetan Ap copies were initially conserved while still in roll format, Vol. 118; photographed by Brandon Dotson, courtesy of the British Library.



Figs 16c and 16d: C.M. Ridding's annotations on the bundle wrapper, Vol. 118; photographed by Brandon Dotson, courtesy of the British Library.

Besides his task of producing a catalogue, La Vallée Poussin was apparently also charged with preparing manuscripts for binding. This entailed numbering each bundle's rolls individually, as well as numbering each roll's panels. Despite numbering these rolls of sutras individually, La Vallée Poussin did not catalogue them

individually, but rather grouped them all together under a single pressmark, number 310. This was part of the sequence 306–455 of his catalogue, which La Vallée Poussin consecrated to "tantric works with identified Sanskrit titles."[43] He makes special mention of this pressmark in the catalogue's introduction.

> The rolls of the *Aparimitāyur-jñāna-sūtra* ([pressmark] 310) deserve special notice. The paper is quite different from the paper of the other manuscripts in the collection. The majority consists of three sheets, each with two pages, stuck together to make a roll of six pages: some have seven pages, an additional half sheet having been added. All the copies examined agree with the two edited by Professor Sten Konow (Hoernle, *Manuscripts Remains*, pp. 289 et seq.) in omitting 8 to 31 [sic] of the Hoernle edition. Some copies have been corrected in red ink, and may record the scribes, the same names occurring more than once.[44]

This notice gives no inkling that this pressmark, 310, includes over one thousand copies of this sutra. Otherwise, the description is helpful as long as one understands that by "pages" La Vallée Poussin meant "columns" of text; this agrees with the two separate measurements given in his entry published in *Serindia*. We shall return to his observations about the sutra copies' format and contents below.

La Vallée Poussin's catalogue entry for 310 describes it as "a collection of rolls."[45] Besides transcribing eight sample colophons and including some references, he supplied an inventory of site numbers, along with the number of "copies" – by which one must understand "rolls" – included under each of these site numbers. La Vallée Poussin's record of the site numbers is valuable as a witness to the state of affairs from 1914 to 1918, when he and Ridding held the sutra copies in their hands. It is therefore worth quoting here in full the beginning of his entry for 310:

> tshe dpag tu myed pa zhes bya ba theg pa chen po'i mdo/
> (*Aparimitāyur-nāma mahāyāna-sūtra*)
> Ch. 0071, I. 1 (5 copies), XIX. 003, XXXIII. 003, XL. 004, 73. VI. 1a (5 copies), 73. VII. 1-3 (3 copies), 73. IX. (19 copies), 73. X, 73. XI (28 copies), 73. XIII. 12, 73. XV. 2 and 8, frag. 10b, 73. XVI, 74. V, 75. IV. 1, 75. IX. 5, 76. XI. 3, 77. VII. 1, 77. XVI, 78. I (23 copies), 78. II, 78. III (51 copies), 78. IV (38 copies), 78. VII, 78. VIII (54 copies), 78. IX, 78. X (50 copies), 78. XI, 78. XII (30 copies), 79. VIII. 5, 79. XIII. 1, 79. XIV. 3, 79. XVI. 6, 80. II, 80. II. B1, 80. IV. 1, 80. VIII. 1, 80. IX. B1, 81. V. 1, 81. VIII (2 copies), 82. II. 6, 83. V. 1, 83. VI. 2, 83. IX. 10, 85. IV. 2, 85. IX. 1 and 6, 86. I (46 copies), 86. III (28 copies), 86. VI. 86. VIa (46 copies), 86. VII (31 copies), 86. IX (12 copies), 86. X (2 copies), 86. Xa (54 copies), 86. XIII (25 copies), 86. XIV (48 copies), 86. XV (38 copies), 87. XIII (9 copies),

43 La Vallée Poussin 1962, xiii–xiv.

44 La Vallée Poussin 1962, xv. "8 to 31" is a typo: the main Tibetan version of the sutra copied at Dunhuang omits §8–§11, as discussed in detail in Chapter Two.

45 La Vallée Poussin 1962, 101.

> 87. XIIIa, b, d, f (4 copies), CXLVII. 2, Fragments 28 (fr. 0060), 29 (fr. XLIII. 002), 33, 38 (3 copies), 39a (written on both sides, roll and scroll), 39b-c, 41, 53 (4 copies), 59, 84 (2 copies), and unnumbered fragments bound in vols. 53 and 55; a collection of rolls.[46]

Comparing this account with the state of the manuscripts today, it is evident that La Vallée Poussin's use of the term "copies" is misleading. By this term he in fact designated rolls. This is important because, as noted already, some rolls contained up to fifteen copies of the sutra, while others contained only one. For example, while the thirty-eight single-sutra rolls marked with the site number 78.IV together contain thirty-eight sutra copies, the nineteen multiple-sutra rolls with the site number 73.IX contain sixty-seven sutra copies in total. Adding up the number of La Vallée Poussin's "copies" therefore gives nowhere near the number of *Ap* copies held in the collection, and also falls well short of the number of sub-pressmarks eventually included within the 310 pressmark. It is safe to assume that those site numbers in which Arabic numbers follow the Roman numerals, e.g. "73.XIII.12," refer to single rolls. One cannot assume the same for those site numbers where La Vallée Poussin did not state the number of rolls, as we know that many of these site numbers include several rolls. It is unclear whether La Vallée Poussin failed to record this data because he chose to ignore it or because it was unavailable to him. For data based on our survey, which shows the numbers of pressmarks, rolls, and sutra copies in each site number, giving also La Vallée Poussin's tally, see Appendix Two.

Looking at the site numbers, one can easily see how they reflect the situation of packing crates one dozen or so bundles per crate. Seven site numbers begin with "73," with the highest Roman numeral being "XVI." Bundles IX and XI in crate seventy-three have nineteen and twenty-eight rolls, respectively. It is also clear that the Tibetan *Ap* did not account for all of the bundles in crate seventy-three, which, as discussed by Takeuchi, contained seventeen bundles in total, many of which include a variety of tantric texts that date to the period after the Tibetan occupation of Dunhuang.[47] Crate eighty-six included ten bundles of Tibetan *Ap* rolls, with an average of thirty-three rolls each. That same crate also included copies of the Chinese *Ap*, which are similarly found together with the Tibetan *Ap* in crates seventy-four, seventy-seven, seventy-nine, eighty, eighty-one, eighty-two, and eighty-seven (see Appendix Two). There are only five Tibetan *Ap* rolls that come from "miscellaneous bundles," and their site numbers, I.1, XXXIII.003, XL.004, XLIII.002, and CXLVII.2, indicate that they were bundled together with painted scrolls, as well as other manuscripts.

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46 La Vallée Poussin 1962, 101.

47 Takeuchi 2012, 207–208. See also La Vallée Poussin 1962, 293–295.

It is clear that La Vallée Poussin intended the 310 pressmark as a catch-all for Tibetan Dunhuang *Ap* copies in roll format, since it includes not only the large bundles of rolls but also fragments of rolls that he identified as belonging to this sutra. (He assigned *pothī*-format fragments of *Ap* different pressmarks, such as 308 and 309.) Therefore, it is surprising that three bundles of sutra rolls with the site numbers 78.V, 78.VI, and 73.XVII, containing over one hundred *Ap* copies between them, are not included in the 310 pressmark. The latter two are listed as pressmark 310 in La Vallée Poussin's concordance, compiled by A.F. Thompson in the late 50s and early 60s, but 78.V is absent.[48] The sutra copies from these three bundles are now assigned pressmarks ITJ 1617 to ITJ 1716. There are also further copies or fragments originating from outside of these bundles, including those numbered ITJ 1588 through ITJ 1615 (excepting ITJ 1601). It is clear that all of these were intended for the 310 pressmark. A note on a curator's sticker on the recto of the first roll from the bundle 78.VI, pressmark ITJ 1617 (Fig. 17), for example, states, "78.VI ~~No. 97~~ 310."

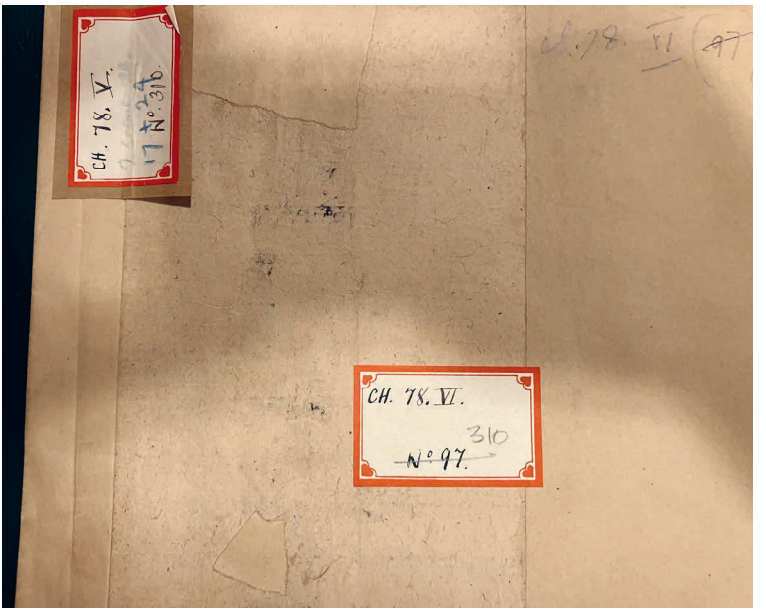


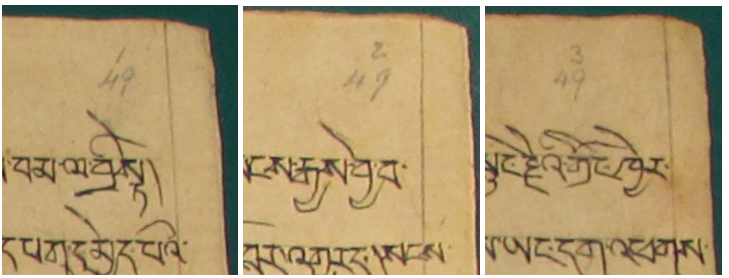
Fig. 17: Curator's stickers on the front of ITJ 1617; photographed by Brandon Dotson, courtesy of the British Library.

48 La Vallée Poussin 1962, 295–296.

Another small sticker on the same booklet's spine adds, "78.V No. 310." This indicates that the rolls with these two site numbers were intended for the 310 pressmark. An annotation in blue, on the same sticker, reads "2 [*illegible*] 17 + 24," which presumably means that seventeen of the fifty-one rolls came from one bundle, and twenty-four came from another. The roll numbers reflect this, proceeding serially, one to twenty-four and then one to seventeen. Only one of the manuscripts in this volume bears a site number in pen, and two others have site numbers on red-and-white stickers and/or in pencil. Taken together with the blue annotation and the roll numbers, these suggest that the first twenty-four rolls are from bundle 78.V and the next seventeen rolls – plus the edited exemplar, which is the first booklet in the stack – are from bundle 78.VI. We will return to these red-and-white stickers after reviewing what seems to have been La Vallée Poussin's parallel task, that of preparing the *Ap* rolls for binding.

1.3.1 Roll numbers and panel numbers

La Vallée Poussin wrote numbers in pencil onto the rolls themselves in order to facilitate the binding of these rolls into booklets. There are two such types of numbers, both written in pencil onto the manuscripts themselves, that pertain to binding. The first indicate how many sutra copies are in a longer roll with multiple *Ap* copies, and the second assign numbers to the rolls in a given bundle and to the individual panels of paper in each roll. The first type of numbering is given in pencil on the verso of the first column of a multiple-sutra roll. In Fig. 13 above, adjacent to one of the red site numbers, "Ch.73.XI.19," there is a "3" written in pencil. This indicates that the roll included three sutra copies.



Figs 18a, 18b, and 18c: The roll numbers (denominators) and panel numbers (numerators) added in pencil to the top right of each panel of paper of ITJ 310.295; photographed by Brandon Dotson, courtesy of the British Library.

The second, more involved set of numbers appear on every panel of every roll, which is to say every bifolio of every bound booklet. These numbers are present in all of the booklets of Tibetan *Ap*, always on the recto, sometimes in the middle of a panel in the upper margin, and other times at its top right. These come in the form of a numerator, which gives the panel (aka "sheet" or "bifolio") number within each roll, and a denominator, which gives the roll number within each bundle. In the case of the bundle of fifty-three single-sutra rolls where the site number 86.X was written on each roll, or example, "1/49" was written in pencil in the upper right corner of the first panel of the forty-ninth roll (Fig. 18a), "2/49" on its second panel (Fig. 18b), and "3/49" on its third (Fig. 18c).

Roll forty-eight, also a three-panel sutra copy, was similarly numbered "1/48," "2/48," and "3/48" on its three respective panels; roll fifty, a four-panel copy, was numbered "1/50," "2/50," "3/50," and "4/50" on its four respective panels; and so on for all of the fifty-three rolls in this bundle. This task was carried out for all of the over one thousand *Ap* rolls in the British Library's Stein Collection. By numbering these rolls and panels in this way, La Vallée Poussin or another curator tasked with this job ensured that their contents would appear in their proper order once they were bound as booklets, and that their panels would not get shuffled once they were separated into sheets/ bifolios. Conservators and binders following these numbers would not bind, for example, the panels of roll forty-nine out of order, e.g. "1/49," "3/49," "2/49," when folding them, stacking them, and making them into a booklet. Nor would they bind a panel from roll forty-nine into a booklet with panels marked with denominators of "48" or "50."

Among the approximately 1,500 booklets they bound, we noted only one such mistake: in the booklet with the pressmark ITJ 1489, the second and third panels of a four-panel roll were shuffled, so the booklet has these panels appear in the order one, three, two, four. Similarly, we found very few errors of numbering at the level of the roll (as opposed to the several contradictions between site numbers, roll numbers, and booklet numbers, some of which we document below.) One such rare mistake is found in ITJ 1588, a single *Ap* copy whose panels are numbered "1/1," 2/2," and "2/3."

In the case of multiple-sutra rolls, La Vallée Poussin followed the same method, but there were more panels of paper to number. In the case of a three-sutra roll with the site number 73.XI.19, for example, he wrote "3" on the verso of the first panel, and numbered its nine panels "1/19" to "9/19" in the top margin of their rectos. Later, when these were bound in London, the three sutra copies were bound into three separate booklets with pressmarks ITJ 310.1149, 1150, and 1151.

It is clear from notes on the manuscripts themselves and from slips of paper kept with them that La Vallée Poussin added these numbers in pencil to prepare

the rolls for binding. A cataloguer's note kept together with the *Ap* copies in Vol. 114 states, "N.B. 73.XVII now in bundle in Stein order – check Poussin's pagination if copies are ever bound!" The note is written in blue crayon (or a very blunt blue pencil), probably by F.W. Thomas. Indeed there are two sets of numbers on these manuscripts: the site numbers in red pen, identified in the note as the "Stein order" – which was likely written by C.M. Ridding – and the roll numbers in pencil (those with numerator and denominator, as just described), identified in the note as La Vallée Poussin's. (We follow suit by referring to these as La Vallée Poussin's numbers for the sake of convenience, but do so with the assumption that this task may have fallen to others to complete.) In this case, these two sets of numbers run in inverse order. Thus the roll marked with the site number Ch.73.XVII.1 was also marked in pencil as roll "28" on each of its panels, and the roll marked with the site number Ch.73.XVII.2 was marked as roll "27." The two sets of numbers proceeded inversely in this fashion up to the roll marked with the site number Ch.73.XVII.28, which was marked as roll "1" in pencil.[49]

There are no dates or initials added to the note in blue, but the circumstances it describes are such that it probably belongs to F.W. Thomas, and to his early review of La Vallée Poussin's work prior to when the rolls were sent to the bindery. Thomas would have presumably added this note after La Vallée Poussin had finished his work in 1918, and before Thomas left the India Office Library in 1927.[50] This shows that the rolls were marked for binding by this time, even though the rolls were not bound until decades later. In this case Thomas was trying to make sense of the results of the work he had commissioned to be produced in Cambridge. This is not the only such example of confusion that stems from one person treating the top roll as the first roll in the bundle and another person treating the top roll as the last roll in the bundle. Returning to bundle 78.VII, which Stein featured in an early plate as "Ch. 05," we noted above that the top roll was marked "78.VII.1," evidently to indicate that the remaining fifty-nine rolls should be assigned serial site numbers on this model. Nobody ever added these numbers, and the only other roll in the bundle with a site number is the last, bottom roll, which is marked "78.VII" (see Fig. 8). When La Vallée Poussin added roll numbers and panel numbers to the rolls of this bundle in Cambridge, he numbered the rolls bottom to top, that

49 Only on the last roll, number twenty-nine, do the numbering systems agree, which suggests that La Vallée Poussin might have mislaid the roll when he numbered the rolls' panels in pencil.

50 Denison Ross (1871–1940), who was briefly employed to catalogue Stein manuscripts in 1914, and who served as Keeper of the Stein Antiquities at the British Museum between 1914 and 1916, was also known to use blue pencil, so it is possible that he added this note; see Wood 2012, 2. It may also be the case that the British Museum and the India Office Library shared similar practices in terms of having different curators and cataloguers use different pencils and inks.

is, backwards. They are now catalogued in this inverse order, with the pressmarks ITJ 310.612 to 310.683. The roll marked 78.VII.1 is ITJ 310.683, and the first half of a two-sutra roll that had been the last roll in the bundle is now ITJ 310.612. The sutra copies from bundle 73.XVII, just described above, similarly follow the order of the rolls penciled by La Vallée Poussin, rather than the order of site numbers inked by C.M. Ridding.

The note's statement, "if copies are ever bound" is echoed by the mention of binding in three other cataloguer's notes found in other volumes of Tibetan *Ap* copies. One, in pencil on a note card in Vol. 94, states, "34 Rolls of M.S.S. Each roll in separate lot. Binder. Aparamitayur." The fifty-five booklets of this volume were indeed made from thirty-four rolls of *Ap* copies. A similar note, which belongs in Vol. 93 but found its way into Vol. 11, states, "86VII. 310. 31 Sheets. 30 rolls. (Each roll done up separate.) Binder. Aparimitayuh." There were indeed thirty rolls in bundle 86.VII, which are now fifty-four numbered booklets in Vol. 93. It is unclear what this note meant by "31 sheets." Another note card, now sitting atop the *Ap* copies stacked in Vol. 113, reads, in blue ink or crayon, "Ch.73.XV + 79.XIII^{5} 310." (The "5" in majuscule might refer to the number of copies from site number 79.XIII.) Below, in pencil, "Aparimitayur" confirms that this does in fact pertain to *Ap* copies, and of course "310" confirms the pressmark. On the reverse of card, in pencil, we read, "39 Rolls each roll in a section (Binder)." These latter notes may belong to La Vallée Poussin. It is unclear what exactly is meant by "each roll in separate lot" or "done up separate," or "each roll in a section." There is no record of these rolls ever having been stored separately in over a thousand individual scroll boxes, as was done for the nearly three hundred Chinese *Ap* rolls kept at the British Museum. Also, "done up separate" cannot refer to a one-to-one relationship between rolls and booklets or sutra copies, since, to use the example of Vol. 93, the eighty-seven *Ap* copies within the thirty rolls in bundle 86.VII were bound into fifty-four booklets.

The last of these three notes is curious for the fact that it seems to bear witness to a group of thirty-nine *Ap* rolls from bundles 73.XV and 79.XIII, of which we can only account for four or five.[51] The note suggests that a total of thirty-nine *Ap* rolls were taken from these two bundles, then collated and assigned continuous roll and panel numbers for the bindery with the intention that they be kept together in a volume. However, La Vallée Poussin's catalogue only lists four rolls for these site numbers, and no site number in his listing has thirty-nine rolls. It seems that either the information on this note card is hopelessly confused, or else that these rolls exist within the collection but have been assigned different site numbers. This would be

51 It is possible that this concerns the site number 79.VIII: in the curator's note an original "VIII" in blue was corrected to "XIII" with pencil.

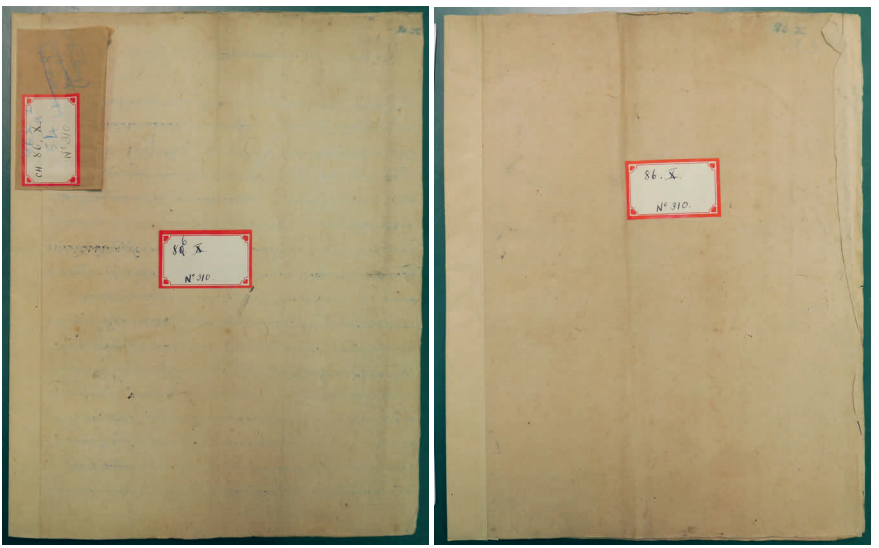
conceivable for a bundle of forty-one rolls where a curator only numbered the first and last roll, and where these were separated from the unnumbered mass of rolls between them. It lines up, albeit only roughly, with the forty-two rolls that ended up bound as booklets in Vol. 105, where eighteen rolls seem to be from one bundle (tentatively, 78.VI), and twenty-four from another (tentatively, 78.V). Another alternative, that these rolls went missing between the time that they were documented in Cambridge and London and the time that they were catalogued, is also possible.

1.3.2 Red-and-white curator's stickers

The 310 pressmark was also assigned to these manuscripts through the application of red-and-white stickers with designs of hearts at their four corners. These stickers usually include both the pressmark 310, and the site number. They were typically stuck onto the verso of the beginning of the first roll in a bundle and the verso of the end of the last roll in a bundle. As such, these pressmarks and site numbers were meant to apply to all the manuscripts kept in between them, in the same manner as the most desultory method of adding site numbers to only the first and last rolls of a bundle, as described above. Many such stickers include annotations. Where these annotations give the number of rolls, this is usually in blue pencil or crayon, probably added by F.W. Thomas. This attention to the number of rolls confirms that the stickers were applied prior to binding, when the manuscripts were still in roll format. On the other hand, some stickers are found on the Kraft paper spines of the booklets (Fig. 19). However, in these cases the stickers have not been applied directly to the spines, but were rather stuck to a different piece of paper that was then peeled and/or cut out and glued to the spine, demonstrating that they were, like the other stickers, initially stuck onto the manuscripts. Whatever their precise chronology, the stickers and their annotations furnish important information about conservation and cataloguing alongside the site numbers, roll numbers, panel numbers, and annotations written onto the manuscripts themselves.

On these stickers and in the notes on curators' slips conserved alongside these manuscripts, we often find one curator trying to make sense of another's work. In some cases one rectifies another's errors, and in other cases they introduce new errors. Only later curators like Ulrich Pagel and Sam van Schaik left dates and initialed their notes, so we are left to contend with the different color inks and different hands, as well as the contents of these notes themselves in order to piece together the order of events. In the case of the fifty-five rolls from bundle 86.X, we appear to see F.W. Thomas with his blunt blue pencil or crayon trying to make sense of two sources of confusion. In the first place, there are two red-and-white stickers

on the verso of the first panel of ITJ 310.245 (Fig. 19), ostensibly the first roll in this bundle, now kept as the first bound booklet in Vol. 95. One sticker is in the middle of the page, and the other is glued to the spine of the booklet. There is also a red-and-white curator's sticker in the middle of the verso of the first panel of what was ostensibly the third roll in this bundle, ITJ 310.247 (Fig. 20). About halfway through ITJ 310.247, on its verso, there is also a rather larger site number in black pen, also reading 86.X. In the top right corner of each figure below, one can also see the site number, which is 86.X in both cases.



Figs 19 and 20: Curator's red-and-white stickers on ITJ 310.245 and ITJ 310.247 (the site number "86.X" is written in the top right corner of each page); photographed by Lewis Doney, courtesy of the British Library.

Examining La Vallée Poussin's roll numbers in pencil in the top margins of the sutras' rectos, the first two rolls are numbered one and two, but then the numbering begins again, at the third roll, which is numbered one. It then proceeds in order to fifty-three, but skips forty and forty-one and repeats forty-two and forty-three. The roll numbering indicates that La Vallée Poussin treated the first two rolls as belonging to a separate bundle. The differing stickers on the versos that are now in the middle of the first page of each booklet suggest how this may have happened. Namely, someone – perhaps even La Vallée Poussin – misread the site number 86.X as 80.X, and errantly labeled and applied the sticker onto the roll that is now ITJ 310.245. As

a result, it is likely that this roll and the next one, ITJ 310.246, were initially kept separately from the other fifty-three rolls, and that the "first" of these latter rolls, now ITJ 310.247, was therefore given the correctly labeled sticker, "86.X." Thomas or someone working under him then discovered this error, corrected "80.X" to "86.X," and reunited the first two booklets with the fifty-three others from this bundle. This may have happened as part of the preparations for binding. The sticker now on the spine of the booklet ITJ 310.245 (Fig. 21) preserves what is probably Thomas's attempt to reckon with the situation.

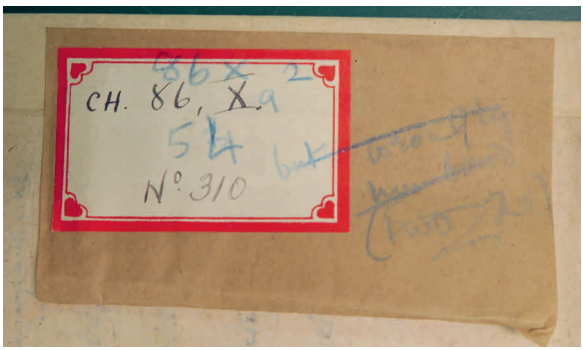


Fig. 21: Curator's red-and-white sticker, with blue annotations, on the spine of ITJ 310.245; photographed by Lewis Doney, courtesy of the British Library.

The blue pencil appears to amend 86.X to "86.X.a" and above this it adds "86 x 2." Between the site number and the pressmark "No. 310," Thomas adds "54" to indicate the number of rolls, where the four has been retraced over a three for "53." Thomas then added, but subsequently struck through, "but wrongly numbered two 2s." Presumably he struck this through because there were also two rolls that were numbered "one" in addition to two rolls that were numbered "two." However, this makes fifty-five, not fifty-four rolls, and he did not strike through "54." Also, the intervention of creating two site numbers – 86.X and 86.X.a – in response to La Vallée Poussin's apparent mistake, was ignored, and does not appear in the catalogue that Thomas had a role in publishing.

1.4 Binding and cataloguing in London

After La Vallée Poussin's cataloguing activity during the First World War, the Stein Collection of Tibetan Dunhuang manuscripts was moved to the India Office Library

at Cannon Row in London. The Tibetan *Ap* manuscripts were apparently still conserved as bundles, probably wrapped in papers such as that pictured in Figs 16a and 16b, when they were transported from Cambridge University Library (and occasional visits to Ridding's and La Vallée Poussin's homes) to the India Office Library in London.

During the 1920s the India Office Library had hundreds of the Stein manuscripts bound into Western-style, cloth- and leather-bound books. Loose leaves and fragments were gathered and bound, and these bound books' resulting "pages" were assigned serial Arabic numerals, either in pencil or typewritten. These books were called "volumes," and were numbered one to seventy-three. La Vallée Poussin – or Thomas and A.F. Thompson, the editors of his posthumous catalogue – refers to these volumes, in fact, in the survey of site numbers included in the 310 pressmark, which concludes with "unnumbered fragments bound in vols. 53 and 55." One such fragment can be seen below (Fig. 22), with its typewritten pagination and damage along the left margin attesting to its prior binding.

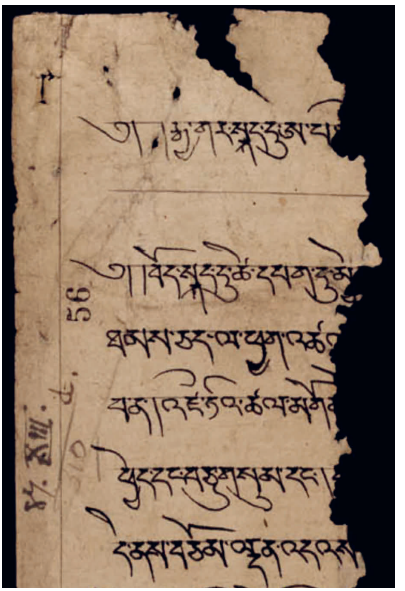


Fig. 22: Pagination and possible damage from binding (upper right) in leather-bound "volumes"; ITJ 310.1204; image captured by the authors from http://idp.bl.uk/, courtesy of the British Library.

Whereas volumes one to seventy-three were bound in large cloth- and leather-bound books, other manuscripts were not bound in such books. This is clear from

the concordance at the end of La Vallée Poussin's catalogue, which once again may have been F.W. Thomas's work and that of A.F. Thompson, who prepared the catalogue for posthumous publication. The concordance gives the site numbers, pressmarks, and also "locations" of the manuscripts. Its only sentence of preliminary explanation states, "[n]umbers in location column refer to bound volumes, B indicates MSS. separately boxed."[52] Pressmark 310, notably, has "B" as its location. An undated typewritten inventory compiled by A.F. Thompson, who worked as assistant keeper at the India Office Library in the 1950s and 1960s, provides some further details. Headed "310: Contents of boxes 1–20," it lists the site numbers kept in each of twenty boxes.[53] Next to the site number, in parentheses, it gives the number of rolls in each site number, which in many cases corresponds to a bundle. These correspond closely to those in La Vallée Poussin's catalogue, but there are a few cases where Thompson's inventory provides a number of rolls that was not provided in La Vallée Poussin's catalogue. This demonstrates that the *Ap* copies were still in roll format when Thompson made her inventory in the late 50s or early 60s.

We have been unable to locate any conservation records or work orders relevant to the rolls' trips to the bindery. It is certain that the *Ap* copies were in booklet format when Sam van Schaik began to catalogue them, as early as 1999. Given the modern conservationist's ethic of minimal intervention, our initial assumption was that these rolls were bound as booklets several decades before this. The use of the butterfly-bound booklet, a Chinese format, is reminiscent of some of the practices current during an active period of conservation at the British Museum and the India Office Library from 1975 to 1982, when conservators were at pains to use Asian methods.[54] However, the information available to us points to a more recent date. Tsuguhito Takeuchi, who consulted thousands of Tibetan manuscripts at the India Office Library and at the British Library from 1988 to 1998 for his catalogue, *Old Tibetan Manuscripts from East Turkestan in the Stein Collection of the British Library*, states that the *Ap* copies were still in roll format at this time: "[t]here are also a considerable number of uncatalogued rolls, which are mostly *Aparimitāyurnāma* sutras."[55] He goes on to state that among the Tibetan texts of the Stein collection from Dunhuang, "there exist bundles of wrapped scrolls...mostly *Aparimitāyur-nāma* sutras."[56] Ulrich Pagel also recalls handling these sutra copies in roll format, and he made annotations on them as late as April 1997, prior to his departure from the

52 La Vallée Poussin 1962, 289.

53 We are grateful to Sam van Schaik for sharing this inventory with us.

54 Barnard 1996, 17.

55 Takeuchi 1998, vol. 2, xvi.

56 Takeuchi 1998, vol. 2, xx and xx, n. 33.

British Library in June of the same year.[57] The clear implication is that the *Ap* copies were stored in bundles even after they were numbered in Cambridge and London, and that they largely remained in boxes ("location B" in La Vallée Poussin's concordance), probably for several decades, before being bound. It appears that binding took place between mid-1997 and 1999, though an earlier date cannot be entirely ruled out.

During World War II, most of the manuscripts of the Stein Collection were removed to Yorkshire in order to protect them. After the war, as a result of several years of work on the part of F.W. Thomas (who died in 1956) and the Assistant Keeper, A.F. Thompson, La Vallée Poussin's catalogue was published in 1962. In 1967, the India Office Library moved to Orbit House, an air-conditioned, glass-walled building at 197 Blackfriars Road in London that included a 4,000 sq. ft. conservation department comprising a purpose-built repair room and bindery.[58] The India Office Library's Stein Collection eventually found its way into the British Library, which was founded in 1973. This involved some back and forth and another period of intense conservation and cataloguing activity. The British Library housed many Stein manuscripts in its "Oriental Collection" (OC), which was moved into Orbit House in 1990 and 1991 to merge with the India Office Library's Stein Collection in order to form the "Oriental and India Office Collections" (OIOC).[59] This merged collection moved to the British Library in 1998 and in around 2005 became part of the "Asia, Pacific and Africa Collections."[60]

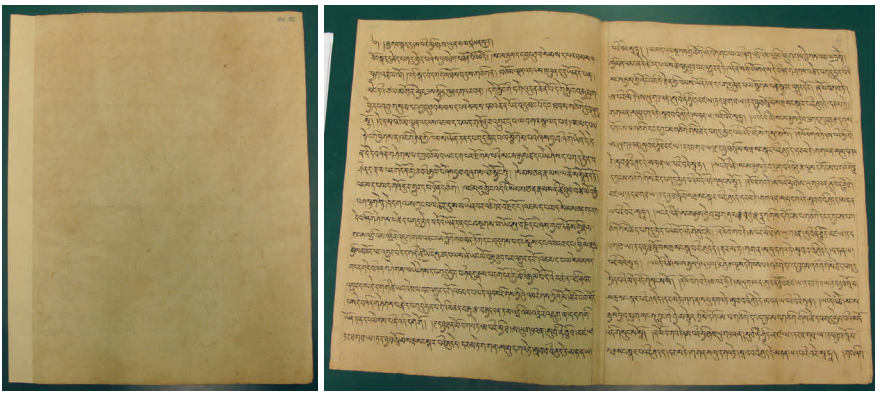
Apart from a few rolls being photographed for microfilm, the bundles of *Ap* rolls seem to have gone largely undisturbed up until the 1990s, in preparation for their being transferred from the India Office Library to the British Library. From the information in La Vallée Poussin's and Takeuchi's catalogues, from A.F. Thompson's inventory of boxes, and from the statements from Pagel and van Schaik mentioned above, it appears likely that it was amidst all of this activity, probably in 1998, that the *Ap* rolls were bound as booklets.

To transform these rolls of various lengths into booklets of uniform size, conservators separated a roll's panels of paper from one another, folded the resulting loose leaves in half as bifolios, stacked three to six of these upon one another, and joined them at the spine with Kraft paper to create a 31.5 × 23 cm booklet. The Dunhuang papers were attached to the Kraft paper spine with a conservator's adhesive such as wheat starch paste. Conservators also used Kraft paper to repair tears and

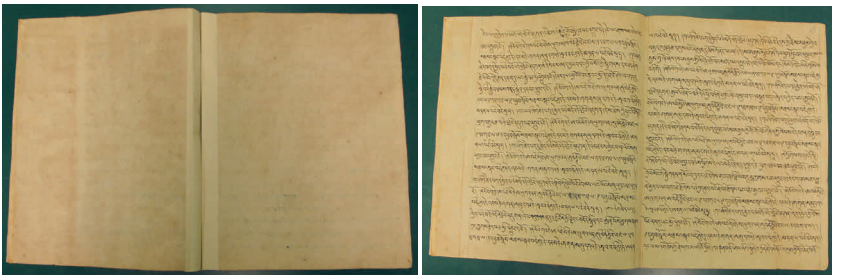
57 Personal communication, 10 Feb., 2023.
58 Lancaster 1966, 173; Lancaster 1969, 7–8.
59 Takeuchi 1998, xix.
60 British Library 2006, 29.

damage and to bulk out the margins of those leaves that became uneven when folded or that measured less than 23 cm wide – thereby making each page in the booklet lie flush when closed. The rationale behind this intervention – besides a cultural bias for the codex format – was presumably that these booklets were easier to store and easier for readers to consult than a rolled-up mass of rolls in dozens of bundles or than over a thousand separately conserved rolls in their individual scroll boxes. Curators left one roll, ITJ 310.1, intact, presumably to bear witness to the original state of these documents. (Three other rolls, ITJ 310.1208, 1209, and 1210, were unintentionally preserved due to their having been apparently misplaced and then rediscovered, first in the 1920s and then in the early 2000s.)

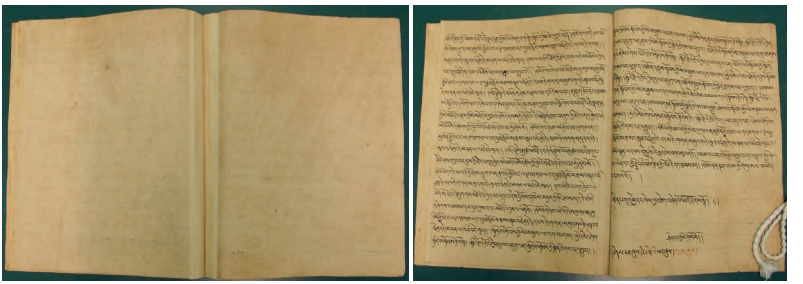
Binding these rolls into booklets, the curators created an object with a front cover and back cover, and with pages and a spine, thereby complicating how scholars and cataloguers describe these objects in light of their previous format as rolls. In addition, the curators' and binders' creation of multiple booklets out of individual, longer rolls, posed serious problems for cataloguers and how they approached the relationship between "item" and "text," or "item" and "manuscript." The photographic documentation of a single booklet, ITJ 310.295 (Fig. 23), is helpful for fully comprehending the transformation of these rolls into booklets.



Figs 23a and 23b: ITJ 310.295, page 1 (cover, originally the verso of the first half of the first panel of the roll, behind text column a) and pages 2–3 (originally the recto of the first panel of the roll, containing text columns a and b). Photographed by Brandon Dotson, courtesy of the British Library.



Figs 23c and 23d: ITJ 310.295, pages 4–5 (originally the verso of the second half of the first panel of the roll, behind text column b, and the verso of the first half of the second panel of the roll, behind text column c) and pages 6–7 (originally the recto of the second panel of the roll, containing text columns c and d). Photographed by Brandon Dotson, courtesy of the British Library.



Figs 23e and 23f: 23f: ITJ 310.295, pages 8–9 (originally the verso of the second half of the second panel of the roll, behind text column d, and the verso of the first half of the third panel of the roll, behind text column e) and pages 10–11 (originally the recto of the third and final panel of the roll, containing text columns e and f); note the colophon with scribes and editors. Photographed by Brandon Dotson, courtesy of the British Library.

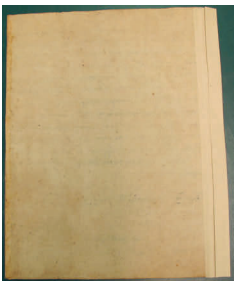


Fig. 23g: ITJ 310.295, page 12 (originally the verso of the second half of the third panel of the roll, behind text column f). Note the Kraft paper spine. Photographed by Brandon Dotson, courtesy of the British Library.

Despite the changed format, it is possible to clearly see where the conservators separated the panels of the rolls (Fig. 24).
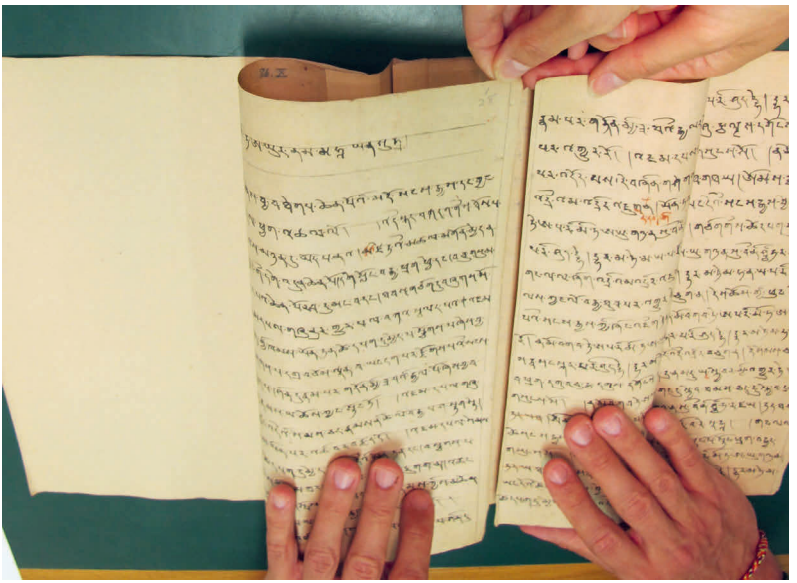


Fig. 24: ITJ 310.296; photographed by Brandon Dotson, courtesy of the British Library.

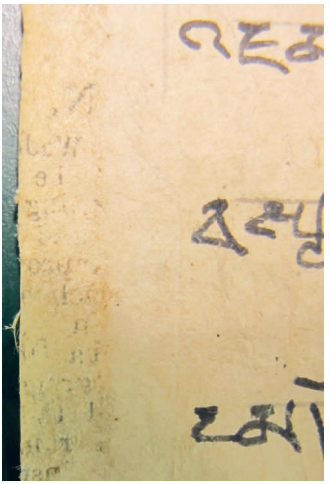


Fig. 25: What appears to be newsprint sucked onto the margin of ITJ 310.266, probably occurring when conservators unglued its panels; photographed by Brandon Dotson, courtesy of the British Library.

When the rolls were separated, the conservators did not cut the panels, but rather undid the original glue that had kept them together as rolls for more than a millennium. Whether achieved by humidification or by other means, the process is inadvertently recorded on the edges of some of the manuscripts. There, newsprint, or some form of printed text, was apparently sucked up by the ninth-century adhesive after the panels were decoupled (Fig. 25).[61]

Now in booklet format, the *Ap* copies could be more easily stored in red quadrangular boxes called "volumes." These same types of boxes largely replaced the cloth- and leather-bound "volumes" one to seventy-three, whose leaves were unbound and stacked in the replacement boxes. The boxes retained the earlier designation as "volumes," and new volumes (that is, new boxes), were created to house the manuscripts that hadn't been bound in the cloth- and leather books, including the booklets of *Ap* copies.[62] These go up to 122, but seventy-five to seventy-nine are not volumes but booklets, and 123 to 154 are scroll boxes. Looking at the volume numbers of the boxes in which the *Ap* copies are now kept, their numbers are almost all higher than seventy-three, and they go mostly from eighty-nine to 119. Additionally, in the case of Stein's regular "library bundles," each "volume" generally corresponds to what had been a single bundle of rolls. Thus Vol. 93 in Figs 26a and 26b below is in a sense the quadrangular version of what had been bundle 86.VII. *Ap* copies are now stacked, up to seventy-nine booklets deep, within such boxes.

Above, when introducing the numerators and denominators that La Vallée Poussin wrote onto every panel, we described the separation of the three-sutra roll with site number "73.XI.19" into three booklets of one sutra each, with pressmarks ITJ 310.1149, 1150, and 1151. This instance of binding followed a logic whereby each pressmark constituted one copy of the sutra. However, this logic of making one booklet equal one sutra, and thereby equating "item" with "text" such that three sutra copies equal three pressmarks, is an anomaly, since this is the only bundle for which the binders separated and bound multiple-sutra rolls with any attention to their textual contents. More often, binders and conservators split sutra copies across booklets. Each booklet was then viewed as an item and catalogued with its own pressmark. As a result, sutra copies – not just a "manuscript" or "item" in the sense of a roll, but also a "text" in the sense of a copy of the sutra – were split across pressmarks. The binding of the roll with the site number 73.IX.8, for example, like 73.XI.19, contained three sutra copies consisting of three panels of paper each. However, in this case, the binder divided these three sutra copies into two booklets. The first booklet, ITJ 310.1052, comprises four leaves/ sixteen pages, that is, all of the

61 Examples may be seen in the margins of ITJ 310.266, ITJ 310.279, and ITJ 310.717.

62 Dalton and van Schaik 2006, xix.



Figs 26a and 26b: Vol. 93, which contains fifty-four booklets bearing the pressmarks ITJ 310.136 to ITJ 310.189; photographed by Brandon Dotson, courtesy of the British Library.

first sutra copy and the first third of the second copy ("1/8" to "4/8" in La Vallée Poussin's roll-and-panel numbering). The second booklet, ITJ 310.1053, comprises five leaves/ twenty pages, that is, the last two-thirds of the second sutra copy and the whole of the third copy ("5/8" to "9/8" in La Vallée Poussin's roll-and-panel numbering). These two booklets were assigned the pressmarks ITJ 310.1052 and ITJ 310.1053. This, the most common method of binding three-sutra rolls, split a single roll into two booklets and divided three sutra copies between them. A standard cataloguing practice of providing incipits and explicits of each pressmark would therefore do nothing but sow confusion by implying that many of these pressmarks contained incomplete copies of the sutra. Another fairly common practice was to include two sutra copies in a single, thicker booklet of six leaves/ twenty-four pages.

If the anomalous binding of the rolls with site number 73.XI.19 (Vol. 119) represents a first attempt at binding, and one that respected the integrity of the sutra

copies, then one can speculate that efficiency came to be increasingly prized in subsequent trips to the bindery, meaning that sutra copies became split across pressmarks as just described, or else were bound two to a booklet. La Vallée Poussin's numbering was agnostic with respect to how the binders divided longer rolls between booklets; these were choices taken decades later at the British Library and/or the India Office Library in London.

1.4.1 Booklet numbers and cataloguing confusion

The binding of these rolls into booklets instigated the addition of yet another set of numbers to these manuscripts. These are also in pencil, but whereas La Vallée Poussin's penciled numbers describe the manuscripts in their state as rolls, the newer marks in pencil number the manuscripts after they were bound as booklets. This is most obvious when these numbers appear on the Kraft paper spines of the booklets. These booklet numbers are sometimes also written on the manuscripts' panels, usually in the upper corner of the first column's verso (first page/ cover of a booklet) or the corner of the last column's verso – (last page/ back cover of a booklet).

The booklet numbers are now essential for navigating these sutra copies, since they effectively stand in for "pressmarks," e.g. "ITJ 310.190." The "pressmarks" are not written on each copy. Rather, one uses the serial booklet numbers within the booklets stacked in each volume. To consult one of these sutra copies one must know the volume number in which a copy is kept. One knows, for example, that the first booklet in Vol. 94 is pressmark ITJ 310.190, that the second booklet is ITJ 310.191, and so on. In this sense, "ITJ 310" or "ITJ 310.190" is not a pressmark or a shelfmark in the usual sense, since it does not indicate where one can find a manuscript in a cabinet or on a shelf. It is rather a cataloguer's number, and it will not easily permit one to locate a manuscript without a concordance that gives the volume number and item number within a volume. The relevant volume numbers, together with site numbers, and "pressmarks," are provided in our concordance in Appendix Two.

As with cases of non-correspondence between site numbers and roll numbers described above, booklet numbers also presented an opportunity to misnumber the manuscripts back to front. Such is the case for the fifty-five booklets in Vol. 94, housing what was once the thirty-five rolls of the mixed bundle 86.IX. These booklets are numbered one to fifty-five according to the numbers written in pencil on their front spines, but are also numbered inversely fifty-five to one based on the numbers on the upper right of the back of each booklet. The numbers on the front spines follow the same ascending order as La Vallée Poussin's roll numbers, whereas those on the versos follow an inverse order. The booklet numbers on the front

spines are underlined, and these were added by Sam van Schaik when he assigned pressmarks to these booklets in 2002.[63] The inverse booklet numbers on the back sides of these booklets were probably added earlier, presumably by someone who numbered the booklets when they were stacked upside-down, and who may have been ignorant of the direction of writing in Tibetan.

In other cases where we find inverse sets of booklet numbers in a single volume, neither set can claim to follow the earlier roll numbers. The fifty-one booklets in Vol. 111 (bundle 78.XII), for example, now follow the order numbered one to fifty-one on the spines of their covers, and not the inverse order of fifty-one to one penciled on their back covers, in the opposite corners. However, in this case the booklet numbers run roughshod over La Vallée Poussin's roll numbers. The bundle consisted of twenty-nine mostly multiple-sutra rolls. Once bound, the booklets were evidently shuffled out of order, such that if one looks at their roll numbers, these latter proceed 1, 2, 3, 4, 6, 5, 7, 8, 13, 12, 11, 10, 9, 14, 15, 16, etc., to 29. The booklet numbers, meanwhile, proceed in an orderly fashion, numbering one to fifty-one, utterly masking the disorder they have created by so doing. These booklets were eventually assigned pressmarks based on these errant booklet numbers, a mistake that probably cannot be undone.

There are further cases where one set of penciled booklet numbers is struck through and replaced with another set, but where these do not follow an inverse order. The booklets in Vol. 105 (pressmarks ITJ 1617 to 1665), for instance, have two sets of numbers on the front of each booklet, with one set on the spine and the other set, whose numbers are struck through, in the upper right corner. These booklets were assigned pressmarks based on the set of booklet numbers written on the spine, which makes the struck-through booklet numbers look like a disordered jumble. Examining the struck-through booklet numbers, they are in fact a mess. There are two sets of twelves, thirteens, and fourteens. Worse, the first booklet, made from a three-sutra roll (now ITJ 1647), is one of the two booklet fourteens, and the second booklet from the same roll (now ITJ 1648) is booklet twenty. Whoever wrote the first set of booklet numbers, now struck through, made very obvious mistakes that the second set of booklet numbers sought to rectify. Alternatively, it may be that two stacks of booklets were somehow shuffled together. Site numbers 78.V and 78.VI are written on only three rolls, so the site numbers can only do so much here to remedy the confusion.

63 Personal communication, Sam van Schaik, 11 Sept., 2014. Unfortunately, there is no log book or similar document that serves as a record of conservation at the India Office Library and at the British Library.

In other volumes, rolls have either disappeared or been wrongly inserted. In Vol. 96, for example, a red-and-white sticker mounted on brown paper on the booklet assigned the pressmark ITJ 310.300 gives the site number "86.XIII.4" and pressmark "310." The writing on this sticker is in black ink as usual, but blue pencil adds "24," referring to the number of rolls. Only this first roll in the bundle was assigned a site number. The roll numbering begins at four, proceeding through number twenty-four. Rolls one, two, and three appear to correspond to three rolls that escaped binding, and which were only assigned pressmarks by Sam van Schaik when he happened upon them in the early 2000s and gave them the last three subpressmarks in the 310 series: ITJ 310.1208, 1209, and 1210. That they belonged to this bundle is suggested by the fact that they are unedited copies of the A1 version of the sutra (on which, see below), by the scribes Be Hing tse, Yang Kog cung, and Khang Btsan bzher – the first two of whom scribed copies in Vol. 96/ bundle 86.XIII, and by the absence of three other likely candidates among the fifty rolls we have catalogued as "other copies and fragments." If we are correct in assuming that these are indeed the first three rolls from bundle 86.XIII, then these three copies raise some further questions. They have no roll or panel numbers, and yet they must have been present in this bundle for La Vallée Poussin to begin numbering the next roll in the bundle "4," rather than "1."[64] Moreover, La Vallée Poussin stated that this bundle contained twenty-five rolls. This would not be the first time that he was off by one or two, and F.W. Thomas's blue pencil rectifies this to "24." Without its first three rolls, this number should be "21." ITJ 310.1208 and 1209 also have curious diagonal cuts that removed large portions the lower right corners of each roll. Both also include ink stamps from the India Office Library dated 10 October 1929 (Fig. 27). ITJ 310.1210 has no stamp and its lower right corner was not cut away. When Sam van Schaik happened upon these rolls in the early 2000s, he added their new pressmarks in pencil adjacent to the stamps, and in the same area on ITJ 310.1210.

Of these three rolls, only ITJ 310.1208 has two site numbers, located in two places on the verso. One is in black ink, on the top right corner of the end of the verso, and reads "Chien. 0598"; the other is at the other end of the roll's verso, in the opposite corner, in pencil and upside-down, and it appears to read "Chien. 0698." The black site number may have been added by Stein himself. "Chien." as opposed to "Ch." was used as a prefix for the 600 or so items that Stein brought back from his subsequent expedition to Dunhuang in 1914.[65] If they are indeed from Stein's 1914 expedition, then Chien. 0598 is one of the highest numbers in this sequence. It

64 Given that these numbers were written in pencil, it is possible that they were erased.

65 Stein wrote that he brought back 570 rolls, but he may have also included in this site number an additional forty-six or so items given to him; Terzi and Whitfield 2024, 65.

is unclear that these site numbers even went as high as Chien. 0698, which renders the latter number suspect.

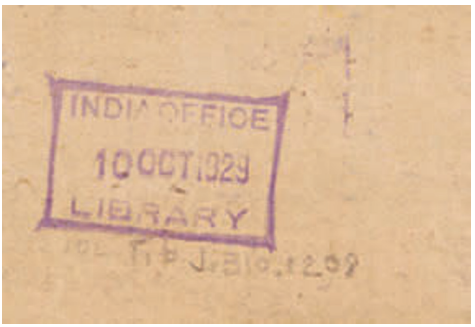


Fig. 27: Stamp and pressmark on the verso of ITJ 310.1208; image captured by the authors from http://idp.bl.uk/, courtesy of the British Library.

The absence of stickers, pressmarks, and roll numbers, along with these cuts and stamps, and the dueling site numbers purporting to be from Stein's 1914 expedition on one of the manuscripts but not the others, are all rather mysterious. The date in the 1929 stamp might suggest that the three rolls were "rediscovered" or returned to the library at this date after having been mislaid or misappropriated. This could resolve how they came to be silently accounted for, yet skipped, in La Vallée Poussin's and Thomas's roll numbering, assuming that these are indeed the first three rolls from bundle 86.XIII. Perhaps it was unclear how to reintegrate them with the other manuscripts, and someone assumed that at least one of the three rolls came from the 1914 expedition and therefore assigned it what may have been the highest available number in that series at that time, i.e. in 1929 after Thomas had left the India Office Library. This does not resolve exactly how this may have happened, how they came to be cut, and where they were kept until Sam van Schaik happened upon them in the 2000s and assigned them pressmarks. That they evaded binding suggests that they were mislaid at least twice.

1.4.2 Cataloguing work to the present

A cataloguing effort from the late 1990s to the early 2000s produced the current catalogue, available electronically through the British Library and the International

Dunhuang Programme.[66] In preparation for this, Ulrich Pagel, the head of the Tibetan collection until summer 1997, went through many of the manuscripts. He left records of two of his interventions concerning *Ap* copies. One is found as an annotation to a red-and-white curator's sticker on the spine of the first booklet in Vol. 118, pressmark ITJ 310.1083 (Fig. 28). As usual, the sticker gives the site number (in this case Ch.73.XVI, with a fainter "1-64" added in pencil) and the pressmark (310). There is also a blue annotation, probably by Thomas, giving the number of rolls as "64." Here a large X has been made over the whole sticker in pencil, and "U.P. 30.4.97" has been added in pencil by Ulrich Pagel, claiming and dating his rejection of this sticker's information.[67] There is a second red-and-white sticker in the middle of the front cover, which gives the site number "Ch.73.X.1-38." This has been left to stand, and Vol. 118's thirty-eight booklets of single-sutra copies all bear serial site numbers 73.X.1 to 73.X.38.

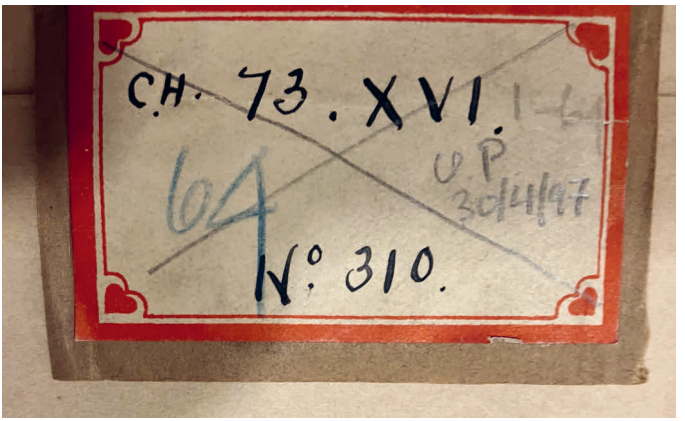


Fig. 28: Red-and-white curator's sticker with Ulrich Pagel's dated annotations, ITJ 310.1083; photographed by Brandon Dotson, courtesy of the British Library.

The inverse, or other half of this intervention is found in an almost identical note on the red-and-white curator's sticker on the spine of the second booklet in Vol. 113, pressmark ITJ 310.971. Here a large X has been made over the whole sticker in

66 <http://idp.bl.uk/> (accessed 13 Sept. 2023).

67 As noted above, Pagel recalls these manuscripts being in roll format when he worked with them. If this is accurate, then he would have annotated this sticker prior to binding, when it was stuck to the roll itself. After binding, this, like many other stickers, would have been relocated to the booklet's spine.

pencil, the site number "ch 73.X.1-38" has been crossed out, and another site number "73.XVI.2" has been left to stand. As before, Pagel helpfully dated his intervention "30/4/97," and wrote his initials, "U.P." Like the rolls in bundle 73.X, the rolls in this bundle also bear serial site numbers from 73.XVI.1 to 73.XVI.64, so it is not immediately clear how the rolls or booklets of the one bundle or volume could be mistaken for those of the other and so mislabeled. Pagel, as noted above, recalls these manuscripts still being in roll format when he worked with them. To add to this simple confusion of swapping the labels of two bundles/ volumes, there is a notecard on the top of Vol. 113 that states, "Ch.73.XV + 79.XIII [5]." This note, already discussed above, may be irrelevant to this volume's contents, given that we have found note cards in one volume that in fact describe the contents of another volume.

From 1999 to 2002, Sam van Schaik was faced with the task of sorting through this unruly mass of booklets and fragments, and assigning pressmarks and subpressmarks to each. His most common intervention seems to have been to renumber the booklets when they had been erroneously numbered back to front, perhaps by binders or staff who were ignorant of the direction of Tibetan writing. He was also faced with more difficult problems, such as that posed by Vol. 114/ bundle 73.XVII. As described above, La Vallée Poussin numbered this bundle's rolls backwards in relation to the serial site numbers, which proceed Ch.73.XVII.1 to Ch.73.XVII.29. A note, probably from F.W. Thomas, rests atop the booklets in this volume, and states, "N.B. 73.XVII now in bundle in Stein order – check Poussin's pagination if copies are ever bound!" In this case van Schaik chose to follow La Vallée Poussin, and added a note alongside F.W. Thomas's: "changed from Stein's order to Poussin's order (SvS, 7/2/02)."

Cataloguers, curators, and binders made an effort to follow the order of La Vallée Poussin's roll numbers, as we have seen in the note about the inverse numbers in Vol. 114. For his part, La Vallée Poussin mostly followed the site numbers, with occasional lapses, as documented above. However, there is no rule that a cataloguer's pressmarks must take account of the manuscripts' site numbers and the sequences they record. It is certainly true, for example, that Giles's numbering of the Chinese *Ap* copies largely ignored the sequencing of the site numbers. To take three site numbers from the same bundle as an example, Giles numbered as 4890, 4891, and 4892 the multiple-sutra-rolls of *Ap* copies with the site numbers 79.IX.13, 79.IX.20, and 79.IX.4, respectively. These were later assigned pressmarks S.1836, S.1837, and S.1838. So, while it may be ideal that the pressmarks should reflect La Vallée Poussin's roll numbers, which in turn should reflect the site numbers where they are given serially, this is probably an unrealistic standard. In any case it was not achieved. What matters most is that the manuscripts have been kept together

and catalogued in a way that preserves the integrity of the bundles, and the rough equation of volume with bundle has achieved this.

As mentioned already, La Vallée Poussin intended that the roll-format Tibetan Dunhuang *Ap* copies should all be given the 310 pressmark. Thus excluded were at least two Tibetan *Ap* copies from Dunhuang, ITJ 308 (Fig. 33) and ITJ 478, which are folia from the same manuscript, and ITJ 309. These are in *pothī* format and therefore were almost certainly not commissioned as part of the sutra-copying project that produced the thousands of roll-format *Ap* copies. Sam van Schaik catalogued 1,210 sub-pressmarks within the 310 pressmark, from ITJ 310.1 to ITJ 310.1210. By the logic that this pressmark was reserved for Tibetan *Ap* copies in roll format, two pressmarks in this sequence are miscatalogued: ITJ 310.59 is the *Heart Sutra*, and ITJ 310.1207 is an invocation to Amitābha.[68] More numerous are *Ap* copies that were intended for this pressmark but to which van Schaik assigned separate pressmarks. These amount to over one hundred *Ap* copies, including pressmarks ITJ 930, 1234, 1235, 1488, 1489, 1497, 1499–1501, 1569, 1588–1600, 1602–1615, and 1617–1716. The last, largest group comprises two volumes (105 and 114) that include three bundles of *Ap* (78.V, 78.VI, and 73.XVII), and which bear red-and-white stickers with the 310 pressmark, as described above. For whatever reason – perhaps because La Vallée Poussin did not list them in his catalogue entry – van Schaik did not assign the ITJ 310 pressmark to these *Ap* copies.

In cataloguing the Tibetan Dunhuang *Ap* copies, van Schaik faced a difficulty that cataloguers of the Chinese *Ap* copies did not. We noted above that Giles made little effort to follow the sequencing of the site numbers when he assigned numbers/pressmarks to items in his catalogue. However, Giles and subsequent cataloguers often had the advantage of cataloguing each item with its own number, whether that item were a single-sutra roll or a roll of multiple *Ap* copies, and where that item's format had not been transformed by curators' interventions. Due to the binding of the Tibetan *Ap* rolls, however, the equation of "item" – in the sense of one roll – with pressmark was less straightforward. We noted above that La Vallée Poussin's numbering of the rolls was agnostic with respect to how the binders divided longer rolls between booklets. Similarly, the creation of these new items (booklets) from old items (rolls) did not mandate that they be catalogued in such a way as to obscure the relationship between one or more booklets that had previously been joined in a single roll. This is precisely what happened, however, when each booklet was catalogued separately with its own pressmark. Their pressmarks give no indication, for example, that ITJ 310.492 (a booklet containing 1.33 sutra copies) and ITJ 310.493 (a booklet containing 1.66 sutra copies) were originally the

68 For a translation and discussion of the latter, see Halkias 2013, 75–83.

same item (roll). The booklet thus replaced the roll not only physically through binding, but as the fundamental unit by which these sutra copies were catalogued.

Whatever its shortcomings, the cataloguing of the Tibetan *Ap* copies is what has made scholars' requisition and consultation of these manuscripts possible, and van Schaik is to be applauded for succeeding in assigning pressmarks to this unwieldy body of sutra copies where others failed. The decision to bind these rolls as booklets can be understood as a culturally insensitive and Eurocentric form of conservation. At the same time, having spent a decade consulting both Chinese rolls of *Ap* copies and Tibetan booklets of *Ap* copies, we must admit that our multiple consultations of almost 1,500 booklets of Tibetan *Ap* copies would have taken us even longer to accomplish if these manuscripts were conserved as rolls. The unrolling and rerolling of rolls also leads to more wear and damage than does flipping through a booklet. This is not to endorse the transformation of these rolls into booklets, but only to offer something more than a one-sided view of this intervention, and to acknowledge that it undeniably benefited our (admittedly slow) pace of research.

1.5 Conclusions

We did not set out to write a detailed history of the conservation and cataloguing of the Stein Collection's Tibetan *Ap* copies. Indeed, if that were our intention, then this sketch of conservation history falls well short, given that there are archival records in London, Oxford, and Cambridge that might allow for more precision about the work carried by Ridding, La Vallée Poussin, Thomas, and others. Our principal aim was rather to document these sutra copies. It was through our decision to record not just ninth-century data (colophons, explicits, etc.) but also twentieth-century data (site numbers, roll numbers, curator's stickers, etc.) that we came to understand that the latter reveal certain crucial facts about the former. Most importantly, the bundle emerged as the single most important unit for making sense of these sutra copies, both in their genesis in Dunhuang, and also in their subsequent storing, conserving, and cataloguing in London. Our insight into the meaning of the site numbers that grace the vast majority of *Ap* copies in the Stein Collection was critical, and bears recapitulating: a site number such as "78.V.1" indicates the number of the roll ("1") within a bundle of manuscripts ("V") that lay alongside around a dozen other such bundles within a crate ("78"). Once we widened our gaze to view the Stein Tibetan *Ap* copies at the level of the bundle, we perceived twenty-six bundles of *Ap* rolls split evenly into two types. There were thirteen bundles of mostly edited copies of the sutra in single-sutra rolls, largely employing the B1 version of the sutra; and there were thirteen bundles of unedited copies, often in multiple-sutra rolls, largely employing the A1 version of the sutra.

We discuss these and other versions in Chapter Two, and in Chapter Three we propose a hypothesis about how these two types of bundles reflect two stages of the sutra-copying project.

It was through this emphasis on the bundle, and the order of rolls within the bundle, that we came to perceive some of the rough edges in conservation and cataloguing, such as when manuscripts were shuffled or misplaced. The site numbers, roll numbers, booklet numbers, and annotations left on the manuscripts tell a tale of many hands at work from 1907 to 2002, not always in agreement with one another. Methods of assigning site numbers ranged from the desultory marking of the first and last roll in a bundle to the serial numbering of every roll within a bundle. The latter method is most helpful for us in attempting to move towards comprehending the original state of the rolls within their bundles, but it also reveals instances where La Vallée Poussin numbered the rolls backwards. La Vallée Poussin's roll numbers similarly lay bare the few cases where, after binding, the booklets were shuffled and misnumbered.

While these observations are secondary to our main aim of documenting the sutra copies, they are perhaps valuable for others working with the Stein Collection, since we have been able to offer some insights into the cataloguing and conservation processes in London and Cambridge, and to demonstrate how and why certain site numbers were used. We have worked very much in the same vein as previous scholars who have taken on the task of making sense of this vast body of sutra copies, by taking stock of their work, and by trying to make sense of it. The infelicities or mistakes that we have found are surely the result of working with such an unwieldy body of manuscripts; it was no accident that these sutra copies evaded cataloguing for so long. The sheer size – and some would say monotony – of this collection of sutra copies has the disadvantage of seeming to invite errors at all stages in its life cycle, from scribing and editing in Dunhuang to documenting and cataloguing in Cambridge and London. Such errors are usually small, though, and these are outweighed by the advantages that can be gained from looking at the sutra copies from the vantage point of larger units such as bundles. Our augmented catalogue makes it possible to navigate the collection by roll number and by site number, so as to travel back through the history of these sutra copies' conservation to see relationships between these manuscripts that have been partly occluded by their having been bound and catalogued as booklets. Besides bringing together valuable data about the Tibetan *Ap* copies, it also furnishes a cross-section of a significant body of the Stein Collection, and a window into practices of documentation and conservation.